A LEADER'S GUIDE TO 100x IMPACT

KILL BUSYness

BUILD HIGH PERFORMANCE ORGANIZATIONS



"You did not become a CEO to chase.
You became a CEO to build."

MANOJ ONKAR
Founder, Management Innovations



Kill BUSYness

Build High-Performance Organizations

A Leader's Guide To 100X Impact

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www.KILLBUSYness.com

Kill BUSYness — Build High-Performance Organizations

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The client stories in this book are drawn from the author's consulting practice over 25 years. Names and identifying details have been changed to protect confidentiality unless explicit permission was granted.

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About the Author

Manoj Onkar is the founder of Management Innovations, an organization-development ecosystem with a singular mission: Reinventing Management and Helping Leaders Build Extraordinary organizations. Over 25 years, he and his team have worked across India, Thailand, the Philippines, and other countries, helping them move from intention to genuine, sustained change.

He has trained over 100,000 people. His leadership workshops have drawn participants from across 30+ industries, and he has personally developed hundreds of trainers and coaches. His clients have included Reliance Group, Tata Steel, TCS, Accenture, Zydus Group, Kirloskar, ONGC, Kotak Foundation, GMDC, PayNearby, and many others.

He was privileged to have delivered customised leadership workshops for the Chief Minister of Gujarat, Shri Narendra Modi (now Prime Minister of India), along with his team of ministers and IAS officers.

His work has also extended to public institutions, including the Lokayukta of Karnataka, police organizations, hospitals, and educational institutions.

Earlier in his career, Manoj served as Master Trainer, Coach, and Head of Training Delivery and International Partnerships at NIS Sparta (Reliance Group), at one time Asia's largest corporate training organization.

He was also a National and Global Faculty with Landmark Education (now Landmark Worldwide), the world's largest personal transformation organization.

He was also a Founder Consultant for DPS Bopal (Kalorex Group) and Zydus School for Excellence (Zydus Group).

His work is grounded in globally recognised methodologies, including Theory U by Dr. Otto Scharmer of MIT, the Balanced Scorecard for strategy execution, and Exponential organization Principles for new-era organization building. The ROAR model at the heart of this work, Reflect, Own, Assert, Run, is the distillation of more than two decades of working with leaders across industries and cultures to close the gap between the organization they intended to build and the one they actually have.

One of his client organizations, a 60-year-old Thailand- based company, was awarded by their Prime Minister as the Best Managed Small and Medium Enterprise following a two-year holistic organization development intervention led by

Manoj and his team. They continue to be recognised nationally.

His current focus is on creating long-term, sustainable organizations through Leadership Transformation, Culture Transformation, and Systems Transformation, and on creating social impact through awareness-based collective action.

Acknowledgements

This book did not arrive fully formed. It arrived through decades of conversations, challenges, failures, breakthroughs, and the generosity of people who gave more than they were asked to give.

The thinkers who shaped the thinking.

Some of the most important influences on this work came from the scholars and practitioners who have spent their lives in their domains of expertise. Werner Erhard, Dr. Peter Senge, the late Dr. Edgar Schein, Dr. Otto Scharmer, Dr. Roger L. Martin, Dr. Robert Kaplan, and Dr. David Norton, this book is built on the inspiration and empowerment we've experienced as students of your work. Our salute to you and what you've provided.

The team that makes the work real.

Ferdi D'Souza, Vivek Chopra, Nilesh Surana, Aljor Pererras, and others who co-created the whole possibility of making a big impact in the world. This work exists because you chose to build it together.

To Vandana Bhansali, Prof. Ramakrishnan A G (Ram) (ex-IISc), Manoj Mani, Shamsundar, Adesh Gothi, Chetan Khosla, Dr. Hiren Panchal, Siddharth Surana and friends, thank you for co-creating the Extraordinary organizations Movement with me. This movement is committed to reinventing management and helping every organization become truly extraordinary, future-ready, energised with the head, heart and soul of its people, and being a positive force in society. What we're building together is larger than any of us.

To the many clients, seniors, and fellow travellers in both the professional and social impact journeys who added to the knowledge, stretched the thinking, and kept the motivation alive, this book carries your fingerprints too.

The family that made everything else possible.

Shrikant Onkar, my father, is now in his eighties and still making a difference in the world. He is still playing table tennis. Still winning medals. You built the foundation of a great life, and you taught me the truth I have tried to carry into every page of this book. You never lose if you don't give up. Giving your 100% till the last moment is a victory in itself.

Mangal Onkar, my mother, is the foundation of our entire family. You had nothing, yet gave everything; you expected nothing and stood for everyone's success. There is no word in management literature for what you are.

The late Dr. Shripad Harshe, my father-in-law, who trusted me and blessed me beyond measure. A saint in the real sense. I carry his blessings into everything I do.

Deepali, my wife, whose spiritual depth brings peace and stability to our lives. You care for both our parents and our children with grace. This book would not exist without the ground you hold.

Chinmayi and Devashree, our twins, are completely different from each other and, in that difference, expand what life means. You are God's gift to us. You remind me, every day, that we're privileged.

To everyone named here, and to the many who aren't: the work continues. So does the gratitude.

Manoj Onkar

2026

For every leader who looked in the mirror and chose to build something extraordinary.

For the organizations that gave us the privilege of walking alongside them.

Foreword

It gives me great pleasure to write this foreword for Manoj. Manoj and I have worked together for many, many years, first in the Landmark Forum and then in rolling out Theory U initiatives in India. This gives me a particular vantage point on both the author and his work. Manoj has a special place in his heart for organizations. He is also a creative thinker and brings his creativity to bear on organizational dilemmas that leaders face today.

There is a fundamental confusion in most organizations today, the confusion between movement and progress. A team can be in constant motion: meetings, escalations, follow-ups. Leaders experience this as momentum. Examined closely, it's an activity.

This is what Manoj calls BUSYness. As this book makes clear, BUSYness isn't an operational issue. It is a leadership outcome, created at the top, normalised in the middle, and suffered at the bottom.

What distinguishes this book is its precision. It doesn't stay at the level of diagnosis. It translates insight into a clear, demanding pathway, the ROAR model:

Reflect: Confront the BUSYness you've created.

Own: Take responsibility without excuses.

Assert: Establish non-negotiable standards.

Run: Build High-Performance as a sustained practice.

Rather than just a sequence of ideas, this constitutes a core discipline.

High-Performance comes from clarity, standards, and ownership built into the organization's architecture, not from more effort.

If you approach this book as a collection of ideas, it will have limited impact.

If you approach it as a mirror, it can be transformative. Because the question it ultimately asks isn't about your organization.

It is about you.



Ferdi D'Souza
Global Consultant & Coach

Praise & Recommendations

"I have known Manoj Onkar for nearly 3 decades now, and in this time, we've worked together in various capacities. It gives me a sense of personal pride to write a testimony for his maiden book, aiming at corporate productivity, which has been his core forte for decades.

Kill BUSYness. Build a High-Performance Organization is a sharp, thought-provoking, and highly relevant concept that challenges one of the most common problems in modern organizations: that of mistaking activity for progress.

The book is compelling in both its message and structure, clearly positioning BUSYness not as a time-management issue but as a leadership and culture issue that begins and hence needs to be controlled at the top. Its central framework, ROAR (Reflect, Own, Assert, Run), provides a practical and striking roadmap for leaders who want to move from motion to meaning.

Since I have witnessed Manoj lead and transform many teams, I can say with conviction that what stands out most is the clarity of

his thinking. The book does an excellent job of combining insight, urgency, and actionable direction, while the 90-day blueprint gives the concept real operational depth. The emphasis on trust, accountability, and this deeper mission is a call to lead differently.

The concept is powerful and has a strong potential to resonate with senior leaders and decision-makers. It is strategic, inventive, and purposeful, a book that can genuinely shift how organizations think about performance, governance, and long-term impact."



Manjula Pooja Shroff
Founder, Chairperson,
MD & CEO, Kalorex Group

"Regenerative leadership is mission-critical for any organization that wants to build a legacy of High Performance.

At Jaipur Rugs, we've lived this truth.

I sincerely believe that the leaders who will shape the next decade aren't the busiest ones; they're the most purposeful ones. Manoj Onkar has written the definitive guide for that transition.

Every serious CEO needs to read this book, not once, but at every stage of their leadership journey."



Nand Kishore Chaudhary
Founder, Jaipur Rugs

"I learned, practised and propagated tools & concepts of Industrial Engineering, Scientific Management, Six Sigma, Lean, Theory of Constraints, Operations Management, Time Management, Strategy, Business Intelligence and AI over 30 years.

Yet, I find this book to be more fundamental. It raises primal questions… and then answers them in a way which wakes and shakes a conscious leader."



Chetan Khosla
Chairman,
Suryojasvi Group of Companies

"Manoj's diagnosis stopped me cold: an organization that runs on follow-up runs on surveillance, not trust.

I had lived inside that organization and built around it for years, without ever naming it.

Leaders deserve language this precise, and a way back this rigorous."

"I have decided to partner with Manoj in spreading this movement."



Utpal Vaishnav
Founder, EightQor Group

Why This Book

Most leaders are running BUSY organizations.

This book interrupts that story. Not to be provocative, but because that story is costing your organization much more than what you bargained for.

A note on the word BUSYness.

Hidden inside the word business is the word BUSY, and that's the thesis of this entire book. Every time you see BUSYness in these pages, remember what it's hiding: the gap between motion and meaning, between activity and progress, between the appearance of work and the work itself.

How this argument was built. Over three decades, we've worked with CEOs and leadership teams across India, Thailand, the Philippines, and other countries. One pattern appeared almost everywhere.

BUSYness was killing their future.

Rajesh Shah sat alone in his Mumbai corner office at 11 PM, staring at the quarterly report. As a CEO, leading a 200-person team, he knew that everyone was working at full capacity, long days, weekend catch-ups, and endless meetings. Yet revenues had fallen for the third consecutive quarter. Actually, nine of the last 12 quarters. "We're running very hard, reaching nowhere," he whispered to himself. His CFO had warned him weeks ago: "Rajesh, we're too busy executing yesterday's playbook to see that the market has moved on."

That night, Rajesh made a decision that felt counterintuitive; he cancelled all meetings for the following week and called his top 35 leaders together for three days of uninterrupted strategic reflection. No presentations. Just the hard questions: What fundamental changes are the markets demanding that we're too busy to see? How do we move from this BUSYness to High Performance?

Twelve months later, the same company had refocused on three strategic priorities, exited two unprofitable business lines, and was on the growth track again. The transformation began not with a new strategy, but with a decision to stop being busy and start being deliberate.

In a manufacturing company in Gujarat, the operations head, Priya Desai, calculated that she sent an average of 47 follow-up messages every single day. "Did you send the report?"

"Where is the update on the vendor payment?" "Have you called the client back?" Her team was drowning in BUSYness. One morning, exhausted, she walked into the managing director's office: "Sir, we're not running a business. We're running a chase machine. Everyone is busy, but nobody is accountable." That conversation became the turning point.

This book is about what we've learned about that problem, and what it takes to solve it.

How to read this book.

Read the chapters in order. Each chapter builds on the one before. At the end of some chapters, you will find exercises and a Mirror Question.

Within each chapter, the major sections are labelled with the chapter number and a letter, for example, 3.a, 3.b, 3.c, so you can reference a specific section in a workshop or team discussion. Exercises, Mirror Questions, and the Notes pages are not numbered this way, since they are tools rather than arguments.

Create a dedicated notebook for doing the exercises. Do all the exercises and use the questions and your responses to reflect on from time to time.

Read the book twice. The second read, a slower one, soon after the first, will be a different experience.

Read, Reflect & Implement.

The leaders in these pages, Rajesh, Priya, Kumar, and dozens more, didn't find a better time-management system. They found a better way to lead, and when that happened, everything changed. People who seemed ordinary came alive and started taking initiatives. The strategy became real because they started seeing the market and the opportunities with fresh eyes. Results followed naturally. That is what this book is pointing at. Not the elimination of hard work, but the transformation of what that work creates.

Introduction: Reinventing Management

- *From Extractive to Regenerative*
- *From Resource to Source*
- *From BUSYness to High Performance*

There is a foundational assumption in management that most people have not questioned. It just felt normal. It still does, to most leaders running organizations today.

Here it is, the ***Blind Spot of the Management World:***

The job of management is to use resources smartly to get maximum output.

Strip away every framework produced in a hundred years of management thinking. This assumption is at the heart of most of them. Treated as obvious.

The following pages ask you to question it.

The Extractive Century

For the better part of a century, management has operated on one foundational mindset: Extract Maximum.

Land, Capital, Technology, Machinery, Raw Material, People, Nature, Everything is a Resource.

We call people at work '*Human Resources*', not sources. Resources to be allocated, used, and replaced.

On the surface, it appears to work. Output surges. Metrics improve. Shareholders are satisfied. Beneath that surface, however, the ground is hollowing.

The hollowing shows up first in the people. Energy quietly withdraws. Contribution narrows. Somewhere, in the privacy of their own experience, each person makes a critical decision:

"Go through the motions. Make the right noises. Don't bring your heart into the game. Protect yourself. Survive."

Then the culture cracks, followed by performance stagnation.

People also start treating the company as a resource to full their goals, nothing more.

The Three Silences

In every organization that has lost its way, these three silences can be felt, heard, and seen by those who are looking.

The Silence of the Soul.

This is the deepest silence. The work doesn't inspire. The game being played isn't big enough, meaningful enough, or



worthy enough to call forth the best in people. When the higher self, the part of a person that wants to contribute to something genuinely significant, finds nothing in the organization worth answering that call, it goes quiet. The organization loses its soul long before it loses its numbers. An organization with a depleted consciousness lays a foundation for establishing BUSYness for individuals and the collective.

The Silence of the Heart.

This is the silence of disengagement. People show up, complete their tasks, and go home, but they don't truly own what they do. When leaders don't create the conditions for genuine ownership, clarity of role, trust, and authority to decide, people default to compliance. They do what they're told to do. No more, and increasingly, less. An organization of compliant people is an organization running at a fraction of its real potential.

People don't bring their hearts to work because they've learned it isn't safe. Somewhere along the way, one disappointing conversation at a time, one dismissed idea at a time, they decided to hold a part of themselves back. With that decision goes the creativity, the courage, and the care. An organization without a **felt** purpose reinforces a need for individuals and the collective to show up with just enough contribution to survive.

The Silence of the Head.

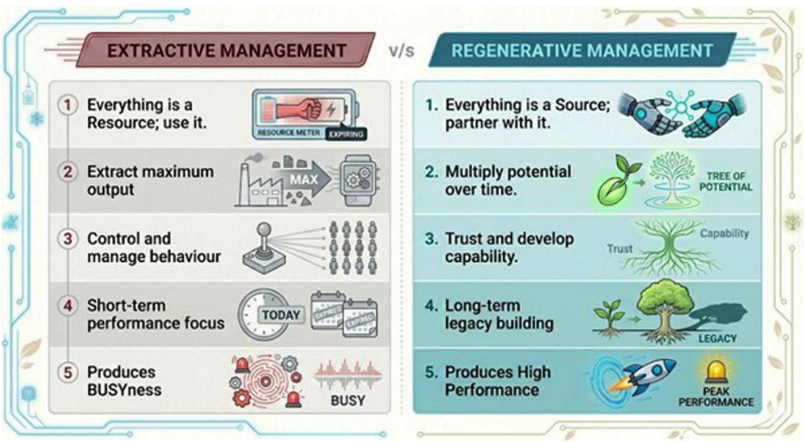
This is the silence of suppressed thinking. People have ideas, observations, insights, and solutions, but have learned that thinking independently isn't welcomed and sometimes punished. When leaders don't create the conditions for genuine thinking, the organization loses its most valuable power: the collective intelligence of its people. Decisions get made at the top, passed down, and executed without much reflection. The organization stops learning. BUSYness fills the space where thinking should be.

The greatest intellectual loss in any organization is invisible: the ideas no one proposed because the culture had already ruled them out.

Look around at your next meeting. Count the number of people contributing versus those who are physically present. That gap is what an extractive management philosophy produces.

When leaders create the conditions for genuine thinking, real ownership, and meaningful purpose, people bring more of themselves to work than was ever asked for. That is a High-Performance organization in its essence, not a structure or a system, but a state of sourcefulness.

The Fundamental Shift



Regenerative Management isn't a gentler, softer version of Extractive Management. It is a fundamentally different

operating philosophy, one that honours the human spirit; one that treats people as the source of an organization's future, not just fuel for its present.

When you treat a person as a resource, the question you ask is: what can I get from this person? When you treat them as a source, the question becomes: how can we collaborate and co-create?

When Paul Polman became CEO of Unilever in 2009, he abolished quarterly earnings guidance and committed to running the company for all stakeholders, not just shareholders. Over his decade at Unilever, Polman delivered nearly 300% in shareholder returns, outperforming competitors and the broader market.

That shift, from extraction to co-creation, was not just ethical. It was the most commercially sound decision he made.

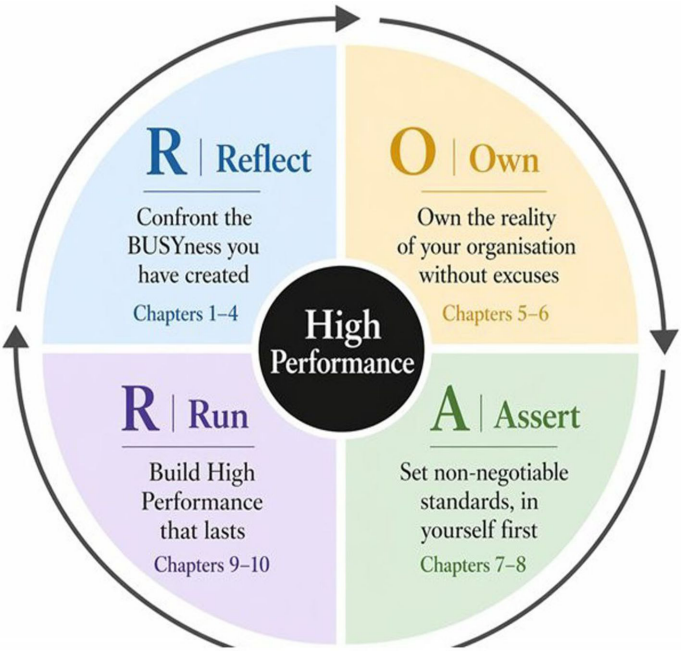
The ROAR Model

R, Reflect.

Confront the BUSYness you've created. The BUSYness you've allowed, normalised, and in many cases, personally contributed to.

O, Own.

Own the reality of your organization without excuses. You're the SOURCE. The SOURCE of the good, the bad, and the ugly. That is both the hardest truth and the most empowering one.



A, Assert.

Assert: Set non-negotiable standards, for yourself first and then for your leadership team.

R, Run.

Run: Build High-Performance that lasts.

The journey to High-Performance begins with a mirror.

1

The BUSYness Mirror

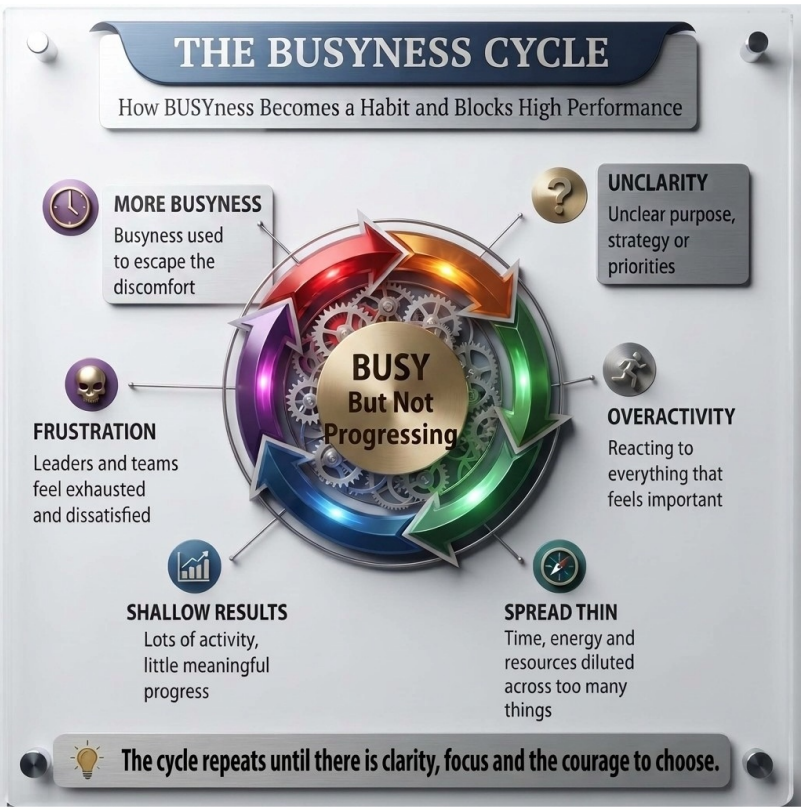
Are you building a High-Performance Organization
Or a BUSY one?

Most leaders know something is wrong before they can name it. You end a week having attended twelve meetings, replied to hundreds of messages, resolved three escalations, and still can't quite name what actually moved forward.

BUSYness gives the illusion of productivity: calendars full and people in action. This is not random. BUSYness follows a predictable cycle, one that repeats until someone has the clarity and the courage to break it.

It begins with Unclarity, an unclear purpose, strategy, or set of priorities. Without clarity, people default to Overactivity: reacting to everything that feels important because they have no filter to separate what is important from what is merely urgent. That overactivity spreads the organization thin; time,

energy, and resources are diluted across too many things simultaneously. The impact is shallow results: a lot of motion but little meaningful progress. That gap between effort and outcome produces frustration, exhaustion, dissatisfaction, and a creeping sense that the work is not worth what it costs. And what do leaders and teams reach for when frustrated and uncomfortable? More activity. More BUSYness. The cycle starts again.



The BUSYness Mirror is the simple act of standing back and looking at your organization as it actually is. It means understanding how clients see your organization and how your best people experience it.

When you're moving a lot, stopping to ask whether you're moving in the right direction feels like a luxury you don't have.

1. Blind Spots of the BUSY organization

BUSYness rarely announces itself. Watch for these signs:

1.a Meetings run on visibility, not decisions.

People sit in rooms for hours, giving updates, presenting, discussing, arguing, managing egos, and surviving. At the end of those hours, though, the question, "What did we impact?" becomes an uncomfortable question; the meeting felt productive, but produced no concrete decisions and no clear actions.

In a BUSY organization, meetings consume significant time while generating few decisions that justify their cost.

1.b Follow-up is the operating rhythm.

In our research across client organizations, senior leaders spend eight to twelve hours every week chasing updates, clarifying missed commitments, and extracting status across email, WhatsApp, Slack, calls, and meetings. The follow-up

message has become such a normal part of the workflow that nobody questions it anymore.

According to one HBR study (2017), managers spend 5.8 hours every week in unnecessary meetings.

Across organizations, 53% of working time is now spent on what's called "busywork", activity that feels productive but generates no meaningful output (Asana, 2024).

In one of our in-house sessions in a Delhi-HQ organization, the conference room held thirty leaders: the CEO, department heads, and senior managers of a 20,000- person company. All perpetually busy. We put one question in front of them: "What percentage of your time is spent on internal follow-ups?"

The responses were shocking. The average response: 60–70% of the entire organization's time is spent chasing work. Not creating value, but managing the failure to create value on the first commitment.

If your organization needs follow-up to move, you have Dangerous BUSYness Syndrome.

1.c Standards dropped without warning

Slowly, one compromise at a time, under genuine pressure from real circumstances, the bar has dropped. The worst part is that most people in the organization don't even realise the bar has moved. The new lower standard has simply become normal.

1.d People just come to work, not to fulfil a Purpose.

There is a difference, and you can feel it. When people are part of a real purpose, a cause they believe in, they show up differently. There is a special energy of being engrossed in creating a future. When that's absent, people are professionally competent and spiritually hollow. They are doing a job, and they will do it until a better opportunity arrives.

1.e The same problems keep coming back.

You solve a problem in Q1; it reappears in Q3 in a slightly different form. You address a team conflict; the same conflict is back three months later with different people.

A BUSY organization is very good at treating symptoms and very poor at addressing the systems that keep producing them.

1.f The BUSYness of Never Growing to the Next Orbit

Why do so many small and mid-size businesses stay exactly there, for their entire lives?

Vikram sat across from his father in the mahogany- panelled boardroom, the same room where four generations of their family had made decisions for a century. At 48, Vikram wasn't young anymore, but in this room, he would always be "the son." The company had survived wars, recessions, and market shifts that had buried its competitors. "We survived," Vikram said carefully, "but we never truly grew.

What happened to the dream?" His father stiffened. "The dream is valid only if you're staying alive in business." Vikram nodded, but saw something else: beneath all the operational issues was a compromised dream, a business that had stopped reaching for what it could become.

BUSYness had filled the space where ambition had once lived.

BUSYness doesn't just waste time: It destroys dreams and ambitions.

1.g The High-Performance organization

High performance comes from the presence of clarity.

- Meetings produce decisions. Decisions that are in sync with the purpose and strategy.
- When someone commits to something in a High-Performance organization, it gets done. Nobody asks twice. That single fact changes the texture of every working relationship in the building.
- Standards are held. Not just set. Organization becomes reliable.
- Problems are addressed at the system level and not the symptom level. It is a learning and evolving organization.
- *Strategy is a rigorously made set of choices, not simply a plan labelled as strategy*. Deep, thoughtful choices made. Many opportunities were declined, and the organization chose to focus on only a few of them.
- People are fulfilling the purpose and are fulfilled.

- Competencies are sacrosanct. Not compromised on the altar of BUSYness.
- Growth is natural. Performance is the norm.

1.h The BUSYness Index

The BUSYness Diagnostic

Are you a BUSY organization OR a High Performance Organization?

x BUSY Organisation	High-Performance Organisation
Meetings end with more meetings.	Meetings end with decisions and named owners.
Leaders spend 60-70% of time chasing what was already agreed.	Commitments are honoured without reminders.
Strategy is reviewed quarterly and forgotten by Monday.	Strategy lives in daily decisions, not in a document.
People arrive to complete tasks and go home.	People arrive to fulfil a purpose, not just a job.
Standards are quietly lowered when it gets hard.	Standards are held firm under pressure.
Departments protect their silos and blame each other.	Cross-functional collaboration is genuine, not performed.
Development happens when there is time – which is never.	Leaders develop their people deliberately and consistently.

The gap between your left-column realities and your right-column goals is the exact size of the BUSYness problem in your organization. Kill BUSYness. Begin High Performance.

Every organization has a BUSYness level. Most have never measured it.

The BUSYness Index is a simple diagnostic, ten questions that reveal where your organization sits between BUSYness and High Performance.

High-Performance Culture Diagnostic

Score each statement on a scale from 1 (Never / Strongly Disagree) to 5 (Always / Strongly Agree).

#	Diagnostic Statement	Score (1-5)
1	Our meetings end with specific decisions and clear accountability.	
2	Commitments are kept without anyone having to chase them.	
3	Almost all people here are clear of and can explain why their work matters.	
4	Our purpose and strategy are visible in the decisions we make every week.	
5	Standards are held consistently – even when it's inconvenient, costly, or unpopular.	
6	New people get detailed and structured onboarding and training before they start their work.	
7	Teams solve cross-functional problems without escalation or politics.	
8	Leaders at every level actively develop their people and have a specific objective and game plan for each team member.	
9	Our senior leaders are the most consistent demonstration of our standards.	
10	This culture would survive the departure of the entire senior leadership team.	

Note: Low scores typically reveal hidden patterns of operational 'BUSYness' that drain execution capacity.

Scoring your BUSYness Index:

Total your scores (maximum 50)

Interpreting Your Score

Score Range	BUSYness Level	What This Means
43-50	Low BUSYness	High-Performance architecture is operating. Sustain and deepen it.
33-42	Moderate BUSYness	Transition in progress. Address the lowest-scoring items first.
20-32	High BUSYness	BUSY culture is the operating norm.
Below 20	Critical BUSYness	Urgent leadership intervention required. Begin today

Whatever your score, here is what matters: you're reading this book.

The following chapters address the gaps directly.

BUSYness is created at the top,
normalised in the middle,
and suffered at the bottom.

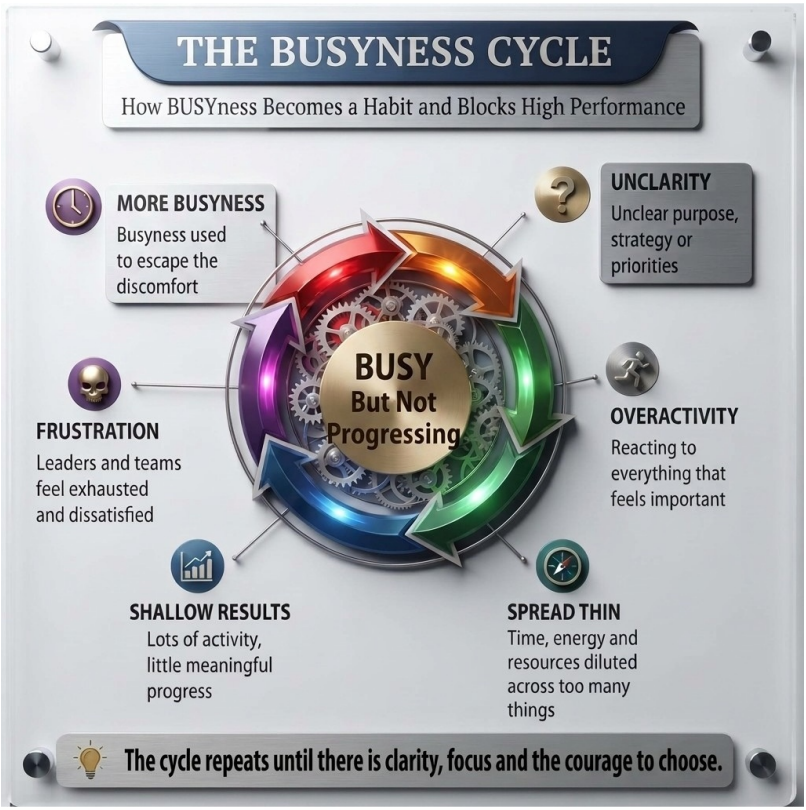
EXERCISES

Exercise 1: Journaling Questions

1. What are the signs of BUSYness vs. High- Performance that you notice in your organization?
2. What are your concerns in addressing the BUSYness in your organization?

MIRROR QUESTION

Where is your organization on the BUSYness Cycle?



YOUR NOTES

2

Purpose

This is the first move of ROAR: Reflect.

Most organizations have goals and targets; what they rarely have is a genuine purpose, and without one, they remain transaction houses, not a legacy in the making. We are not talking about vision statements, mission statements, or any other statements. We are talking about a lived purpose that influences everything else in the organization.

Human beings want their lives to matter.

They want to be part of something bigger than themselves.

When we go beyond the survival and scarcity mindset and reflect, we can inquire into the fundamental questions:

Who am I? and What is my purpose? These are questions that can be answered by individuals and also by organizations. Connecting to these questions powerfully gives a new context

for your work and your organization, beyond mere operational survival. It gives you and your team the sense of 'Building the Temple' instead of being BUSY laying bricks.

1. What Purpose Is Not

It is not a goal. It is not a destination.

Purpose is the WHY of your game and its impact on the world.

An organization can hit every goal it sets and still be purposeless. It can lead its market and still be dying inside.

Purpose answers a simple question: what would our stakeholders miss if we didn't exist?

2. What does a purpose do?

1. It gives people the energy to pursue what seems impossible.
2. It brings together people who have similar intentions.
3. It becomes the reference point for all decisions, people, projects, investments, and what to walk away from.
4. It gives patience and perseverance for the long- sustained journey.
5. Excellence becomes a natural part of the game.

The purpose is the North Star, the decision framework for everything and everyone. It decides what gets priority, what gets funded, who gets hired, what gets refused, and what people will endure when the work becomes difficult.

2.a A purpose makes decisions easier and faster.

When you are clear about what your organization exists to do, a large number of decisions answer themselves. Instead of asking 'What should we do?' the question becomes 'Does this serve our purpose?' and suddenly the choice is clear.

2.b Purpose and the BUSYness Connection

BUSYness is, in part, what fills the space where purpose should be.

When people know why they're here, they tend to prioritise naturally. They make good calls about where to invest their energy. They protect what matters and let go of what doesn't.

When purpose is absent, people default to activity.

They fill their days with motion because motion feels better than uncertainty. Meetings, emails, and updates create the comforting sensation of being needed, of contributing, even if none of it is actually moving the organization forward.

2.c Purpose is not a value exercise. It is performance architecture.

Evidence: The Impact of Purpose & Management

Key Finding	Source
Purpose-led companies: 4x higher valuations	*Deloitte, 'The Purpose Premium'*
40% higher retention; 30% higher innovation	*Deloitte, C-suite insights on purpose*
Purpose-driven companies; 5x CAGR over S&P 500 over 20 years	*Jump Associates, Payback on Purpose study*
75% of workers rank purpose above salary	*Deloitte Global Millennial Survey 2024*
Employees finding meaning: 4x more likely to report high engagement	*McKinsey, April 2021*
70% of team engagement is linked directly to the immediate manager	*Gallup, State of the Global Workplace 2025*

* * *

Anand, the CEO of a mid-sized enterprise in South India, walked into our two-day workshop carrying a full-page document of urgent questions. We listened carefully, then made an unusual request: "Set the list aside. We will return to it after we answer a deeper question: Why does your organization exist? What is the real purpose you're here to fulfil?"

By the end of the second day, they and their leadership team had co-created a purpose they were genuinely passionate about. The shift was palpable. The co-founder stood up and said: "In two days, we've moved further than we did in the past two months. We finally know what we're building together." The problem list sat untouched on the table, and somehow, half the problems no longer seemed relevant.

2.d Purpose attracts the right people.

Purpose attracts people who feel deeply connected to what the organization stands for and would be drawn here even if several other options were available.

Research shows that people are 78% more likely to want to work for an organization that leads with purpose (Porter Novelli, 2021).

2.e Purpose retains people even in difficult times.

Every organization goes through hard periods. In most organizations, those periods produce attrition; the good people leave because nothing is anchoring them there.

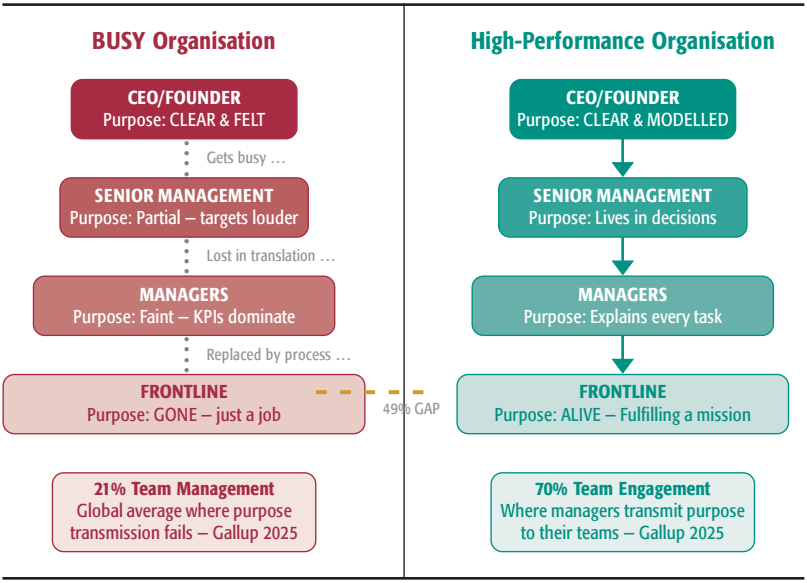
2.f Unfortunately, Purpose Disappears into the Middle

The CEO means it. The management team is aligned. Then somewhere the purpose gets lost. It is communicated, but it doesn't land, and if *it lands and inspires people, it gets buried under the BUSYness.*

What arrives at the frontline is a set of KPIs and a list of tasks. The '*why*' has evaporated.

Research shows that 70% of team engagement is influenced by the immediate manager (Gallup, 2025). Purpose survives only when managers translate it into daily behaviour.

The Purpose Transmission Gap



Purpose dies on its way down in most organizations.
High Performance Organizations live the purpose differently.

If your managers can't explain why the work matters, you don't have a purpose. You have a slogan.

BUSYness creates that gap, layer by layer, as purpose gets replaced with things to do on the way down.

(Note: The events described in the following section, as well as all the cases mentioned in the book, are based on real situations. Identifying details, including the industry, scale, and specific circumstances, have been altered to protect confidentiality. The pattern and its consequences are representative of many similar situations across industries.)

2.g When Purpose Disappears: The organizational Cost

When senior leaders of an infrastructure giant first approached us about articulating a common purpose, the energy was genuine. "We want to align the group," the CFO explained. "We are operating as separate kingdoms. A shared purpose could unite us." We began the planning with optimism.

Two months into the planning, halfway through finalising the intervention, the group chairman called a meeting. No pleasantries. He leaned forward and delivered his verdict in a voice that left no room for discussion: "Purpose does not make any difference in how business is run. We don't need this." The intervention died that day.

In a painful sense, he was right.

An organization that has been distracted from its founding purpose for a long time and is now BUSY hiding and managing the consequences of that drift finds both "purpose" and "co-creation" to be dangerous conversations.

Twenty-two months later, the group collapsed. When the news broke, chaos followed. The damage to all stakeholders, investors, employees, vendors, and the communities that depended on their projects was catastrophic.

The refusal was not to the intervention. It was to the discomfort of looking at what the business had become. BUSYness without purpose eventually becomes self- destructive.

Anand's team and the clients who chose to do the hard work of co-creation built something no one could take from them, a spirit that carries an organization through every season, good and bad. That same opportunity is open to every leader reading this book.

EXERCISES

Exercise 1: The Purpose Translation Test

Write down why your organization exists.

Then ask three people, one senior leader, one manager, and one frontline employee, to do the same.

Compare all four sentences side by side. Where do they align? Where do they diverge?

Exercise 2: The Purpose Draft

1. What problem does your organization exist to solve, not for shareholders, but for the people or world it serves?
2. Who would suffer if your organization did not exist? What would be missing from their lives?
3. What is the one contribution your organization makes that no other organization makes in quite the same way?
4. What would need to be true about the world for your organization's work to be finished?
5. If your best people, the ones who could work anywhere, were asked why they chose to stay, what would they say?

YOUR NOTES

3

Strategy

Strategy is Business Everything else is BUSYness.

As strategy scholar Roger Martin argues, most organizations don't have a strategy. They have a plan. A well-constructed, overly discussed plan with targets, timelines, and everything else. And it sits in a document, or a deck, and it gets referenced in quarterly business reviews, and it gives everyone a comfortable sense that the organization knows where it's going.

Strategy is a set of interconnected choices, and a real choice costs you something, by definition.

Most organizations are unwilling to make that sacrifice. And so, what gets called a strategy is actually a collection of intentions, things the organization hopes to do, without the discipline of choosing what it won't do.

BUSYness is often the consequence of *this* absence of strategic choice.

When everything is a priority, nothing is. When there's no clear answer to "What do we not do?", every opportunity feels like it should be explored. The organization spreads itself thin: ***active everywhere, decisive nowhere.***

3.a A Strategy as a Set of Interconnected Choices

Inspired by Michael Porter's work, we ask these simple questions for every client company to reflect on:

1. Which customer segments do you wish to serve?
2. Which needs of these customer segments do you wish to serve?
3. How do you serve these needs in a way that gives you a long-term competitive advantage?

These questions require slowing down, thinking, collecting information, reflecting, discussing, and ultimately making a conscious choice.

When organizations see the market and customer needs afresh, they can create solutions that may make little sense to others but make a great deal of sense to the target audience, because they are addressing problems their customers have been living with, sometimes without even seeing them as solvable problems, but simply as a reality of the situation.

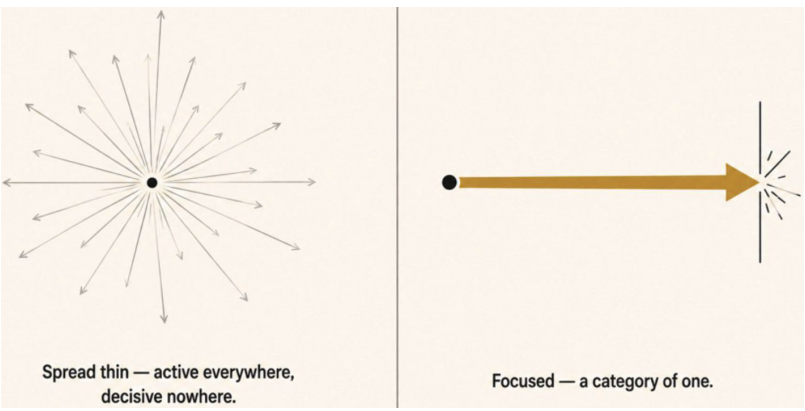
What do you do that creates value in a way that competitors can't easily replicate, or don't choose to replicate?

The work to be done:

- Answer these three questions in depth until you have an "aha" moment and the clients say, "Wow, if you offer this product or service to us, that would be incredible."
- Have every decision in the company be in sync with your answers to the above 3 questions.

That is the spirit of a strategy-focused organization.

To answer these three questions deeply and to have the organization align around those answers is to kill BUSYness and build a new environment.



3.b How BUSYness Hides the Absence of Strategy

One of the most dangerous things BUSYness does is hide the absence of strategy.

When an organization is in full motion, busy with meetings, projects, budgets and reviews, there's no obvious signal that strategy is absent.

What you can't see, from inside the web of incessant activity, is whether any of it is actually moving the organization in sync with its long-term strategy.

An organization can be BUSY for years while its competitive position erodes. The market is shifting in a direction the BUSY organization is too occupied to sense.

3.c The Incumbent's Dilemma

Success builds a trap. The very things that made an organization successful, e.g., its products, its processes, its culture, its relationships, over time become the box that prevents it from becoming greater.

What worked in the past influences what we believe is true, and what we believe is true becomes the box we can't see our way out of. We create our own limits when we mistake our beliefs for reality.

In the 1990s, one Indian electronics manufacturer was extremely successful. Their televisions were in millions of homes across India.

When Samsung and LG entered India in the late 1990s, the company had every advantage: established distribution, customer trust, manufacturing expertise, and deep pockets. The strategic choice was obvious: double down. Invest in R&D. Upgrade designs. Match the global players on quality and innovation. Become India's Samsung.

Instead, the boardroom diversified. Capital that should have gone into product development went into new ventures. Management attention was dispersed across industries. The core electronics business slowly hollowed out.

By the time management woke up, Samsung and LG owned the Indian market. The company that had every reason to lead the market was busy chasing new opportunities while its core business eroded.

* * *

For over fifty years, Ambassador was India's dominant car, in government driveways, on national highways, across every tier of the market. Hindustan Motors owned Indian roads completely. Then in 1983, Maruti Suzuki entered with the Maruti 800: smaller, more fuel-efficient, and unmistakably modern.

Hindustan Motors had a choice: innovate. They didn't choose to innovate. They produced essentially the same vehicle with only cosmetic changes. The design still belonged to 1950s Britain. Fuel efficiency was poor. Competitors offered power

steering, air conditioning, and better mileage. Production ceased in 2014.

The factory that had once employed thousands fell silent. A company that had defined Indian motoring for half a century discovered too late that you cannot defend your way to the future.

For decades, HMT was India's dominant watch brand, gifted at first jobs, worn by engineers, present in virtually every household. When Titan Industries launched in 1987, HMT executives barely responded. "Quartz? That's a fad. Fashion watches? People want reliability, not trends." While Titan opened modern showrooms and made watches desirable, HMT kept optimising mechanical movements. They were perfecting what they had always done while the market redefined what a watch could be. By 2016, HMT shut down production entirely.

Hundreds of companies go strategically bankrupt first. Then operationally bankrupt.

3.d Long-Term Thinking and Short-Term Thinking

If you aren't thinking long-term, you aren't thinking. You are reacting.

BUSYness produces a very specific leadership cost: short-term thinking.

Short-term thinking is the orientation towards this quarter and this financial year. It responds to what's urgent. It optimises for the near term. It underinvests in the capabilities, relationships, and strategic positions that would make the organization powerful five or ten years from now.

3.e Saying No

The most important word in the strategy game is "NO".

Saying NO to a lot of good ideas, so that you can say a meaningful YES to one.

In a BUSY organization, the word "no" is rarely heard. New initiatives are launched. Old initiatives are never killed. Every opportunity feels like it should be explored. The result is an organization doing a hundred things adequately rather than ten things exceptionally.

High-performance organizations are ruthlessly focused.

They make the real choice about whom to serve, what to serve, and how to serve. They stay true to that choice and avoid the BUSYness of distractions and the pressure to run after every good idea.

Mohit Sharma's story is one we return to often when leaders say they can't focus. As a consultant in Maharashtra, Mohit had built a reputation as the go-to expert in lean management. When we first met him, he was running five businesses simultaneously: lean consulting, training programmes,

insurance, marketing products, and more. All were underperforming. "I know I'm spread thin," he admitted. "But I can't let any of them go. They all have potential." His lean consulting practice was getting maybe 30 percent of his attention, the very thing that could have made him a national authority in his field.

Our initial conversations met polite resistance. Mohit could see the logic: focus everything on lean consulting, become a dominant player, and let go of everything else. But the commitment required was real. "I understand what you are saying, but you are asking me to walk away from revenue. Real revenue. Relationships I've built over the years. What if I bet everything on lean consulting and it doesn't work out?" This is what strategic choice actually costs, not money or time, but the willingness to close doors.

Most leaders, when they reach this moment, retreat. They choose the comfort of doing many things adequately over the terror of doing one thing extraordinarily.

Several weeks later, Mohit called with his decision. "I'm doing it. I'm shutting down everything except lean consulting, handing some over, closing the rest. It's terrifying. But the choice is made."

Unfortunately, fourteen months into the transformation, Mohit mentioned casually, "We're doing this personal transformation training programme. Well, this client specifically asked. It is just a one-time thing."

One programme became three. The word "no" was getting harder to say. Growth creates its own gravitational pull towards compromise. Success makes you feel invincible, until it makes you vulnerable again.

We had a straight conversation: "Mohit, you're doing it again. You're drifting back into being everything to everyone." The pain in his face was real; he knew it was true. This time, the choice went deeper. Not just lean consulting, but lean consulting for a specific client profile only. The target audience became manufacturing companies above a certain scale. Everything else? Not to be pursued. The discipline required was brutal.

The results were unambiguous. The business grew 15x in two years, not 15 per cent, fifteen times. Mohit called after closing his largest-ever deal. "This client wouldn't have taken my call three years ago. Now they're paying us more for one transformation than I made in an entire year running five businesses."

That is what becomes inevitable when an organization stops distributing its capability across everything and concentrates it on the one thing it can do better than anyone else.

Leaders who have made and sustained this choice consistently describe a counterintuitive experience: as the focus narrows, the trajectory accelerates.

The three questions at the heart of strategic choice, which customers, which needs, which competitive advantage, are

not answered once and set aside. They are returned to at a regular frequency and fine-tuned.

The next chapter asks what capability the organization needs to execute that strategy, because a clear strategic choice, without the competency to deliver it, is only a well-written intention.

EXERCISES

Exercise 1: The Three Strategic Choices

Discuss with your leadership team:

- What customer segments are you choosing to serve?
  - What needs of these segments are you choosing to serve?
  - How are you going to serve these needs in a way that gets you a long-term competitive advantage?

MIRROR QUESTION

Is your organization idea-focused rather than strategy-focused?

Are you willing to transform into a strategy-focused organization?

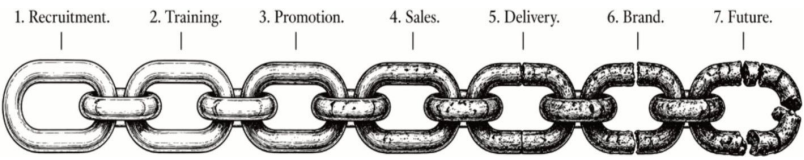
Are you willing to say 'No' to some good ideas?

YOUR NOTES

4

The Competency Chain

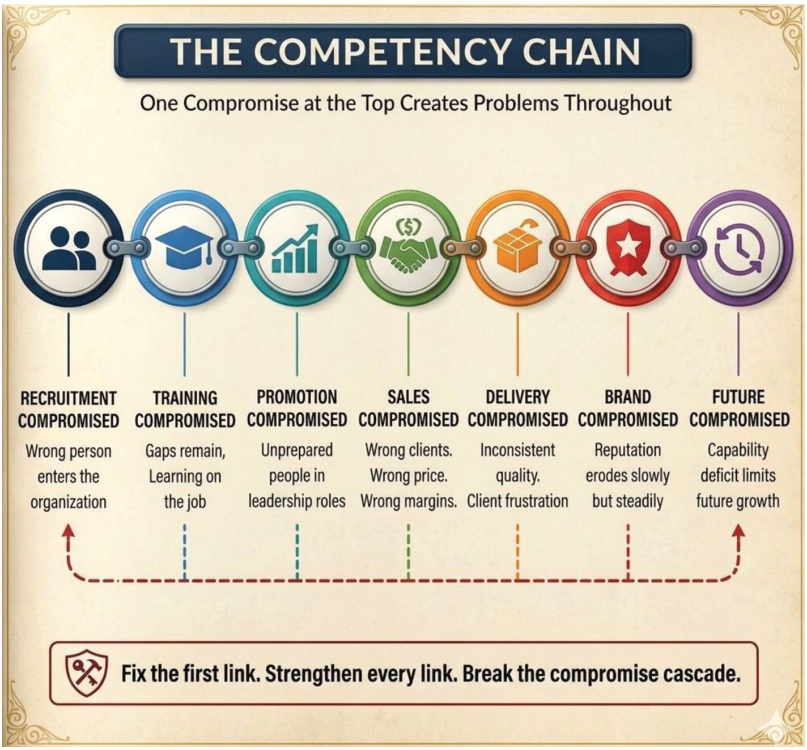
Good enough isn't High Performance.
Good enough is the architecture of BUSYness.



Not Seven Problems. One Chain.

The Competency Chain describes how compromise actually spreads through an organization. Each link is broken by the one before it. Each compromise makes the next compromise more necessary and easier to justify.

It begins with a single decision made under pressure. It ends with an organization that can't fulfil its purpose, not because the people aren't working hard, but because the architecture of competency was compromised before the work even began.



4.a Recruitment Compromised

Every hire is a decision about what kind of organization you're building. BUSY organizations treat every hire as an operational necessity. High-performance organizations treat every hire as a strategic investment.

Finding the right person takes time. You don't have time. So you hire the available candidate instead of the right one. It sounds reasonable at the moment, and that's the trap, because you rarely get a clean second chance to correct it later.

Neha Patel, CTO of a forty-person IT services firm in Pune, described the pattern precisely. "We'd bring someone in, they'd look good in interviews, and three months later we'd realise they couldn't do the job. Then we were back to recruiting while the projects suffered."

We asked a different question: what if recruitment were a strategic investment, not an operational necessity? They rebuilt the entire process end to end, from role design through competency-based assessment to a paid work trial, where candidates worked in the real team on the real job before either side made the final call.

"We lost some candidates who didn't want to invest the time," Neha admitted. "But those were exactly the ones we didn't need. The people who stayed were the ones who wanted to prove they could deliver, and wanted to find out for themselves whether this was a team worth joining."

In under two years, the company grew from 40 people to over 300. More importantly, attrition dropped to 8 per cent in an industry where 25 per cent is the norm. Client satisfaction reached its highest point. "We stopped treating recruitment as filling seats and started treating it as building our future," Neha said. "That single shift changed everything."

Compromise at the point of entry, and you compromise everything downstream.

4.b Training Compromised

The new hire joins. A training programme exists somewhere in the organizational records, but operational demands always take priority. The person learns on the job, which means they learn the existing habits, the existing shortcuts, and everything that actually needs to change.

Structured onboarding improves new-hire retention by 82% and measurably increases productivity (Glassdoor, 2015). Few organizations build to that standard, and fewer still build it into a system that survives a change in leadership.

A national telecom company built its early front-line capability on exactly this foundation, structured multi- week programmes for store staff and franchise managers, certified trainers, and supervised in-store coaching.

Then a new management team arrived. "We can do these training programmes in a day. Two days, maximum. Keep costs low." Multi-week programmes became single-day events. Trainer certification was dropped. In-store coaching stopped. Training still appeared on the calendar, still showed up in the activity reports, still got counted in the dashboard. But it had stopped being a competency- building activity.

What showed up in the business? Customer satisfaction scores fell gradually and then sharply. Store conversion rates dropped. Franchise partners began complaining that the support they'd been promised wasn't materialising. The gap between what the brand claimed and what a customer

experienced at the front line widened with every passing quarter.

4.c Promotion Compromised

The best salesperson becomes the sales manager. The most senior employee becomes the supervisor. The logic seems sound: reward your best performers with advancement, because tenure deserves to be recognised.

Domain excellence and leadership excellence, though, aren't the same thing.

A 2019 study analysed data from 214 companies and 53,035 workers. The finding was stark: companies systematically promote their best salespeople into management roles, even though individual sales performance is negatively correlated with management performance. The better someone is at selling, the research suggests, the worse they're likely to be at leading a sales team.

Promoting people into leadership without preparing them for leadership doesn't reward them. It sets them up to fail.

This pattern recurs with notable consistency across industries. One instance stays with us. A plant manager at a manufacturing company was promoted on the strength of his technical expertise and long tenure. He was a gifted engineer; he knew the machines, the materials, and the processes better than anyone on the floor. What nobody asked, what the organization never paused to examine, was

whether he knew how to lead people, whether he could coach someone whose work fell short, hold a standard with a team that was used to doing things a certain way, or demand excellence without undermining the people who had to deliver it.

☐ A bad hire costs 30% of first-year earnings, up to $240,000 in total. US Dept. of Labor, SHRM Human Capital Benchmarking Survey 2023
☐ 80% of employee turnover stems from poor hiring decisions. CareerBuilder; Blue Signal Search 2024
☐ Structured onboarding lifts retention 82% and productivity 70%. Glassdoor 2015; SHRM
☐ Top salespeople get promoted to manager despite a negative correlation with management success. Altman et al., "Promotions and the Peter Principle," Management Science, 2019
☐ Managers drive 70% of the variance in employee engagement. Gallup, State of Global Workplace 2025/25

4.d Sales Compromised

With a team built on compromise, the sales process follows suit. The wrong clients get pursued and signed, the wrong fit, the wrong margin, the wrong expectations. The team is under pressure to generate revenue, and pressure produces the same thing in sales that it produces everywhere else: short-term optimisation at the expense of long-term health.

Suresh Reddy, managing director of an auto components manufacturer, called us in frustration. "We're winning bids left and right, but somehow we're not making money. I don't understand it." We asked to see his win-rate data. The

numbers told a brutal story: a 25% win rate by number of bids, but only 5% by value. He was winning a lot of small orders while losing the large, profitable ones, same processing costs, same management overhead, no profit to show for it.

We picked one "win" at random for a deep analysis: a ₹38.5 lakh order (roughly USD 46,000). On paper, it showed a ₹2.5 lakh profit (about USD 3,000), and Suresh was pleased with it. Then we did the real math, full cost accounting, hidden overheads, time allocation. The celebration turned to silence. The "profitable" order had actually cost the company ₹62,000 (about USD 750). "How many more winning bids are quietly bankrupting us?" Suresh asked, his face pale.

Not all orders are business. Some are BUSYness.

Not all customers are business. Some are BUSYness.

4.e Delivery Compromised

Two CEOs, six hundred kilometres apart, were facing the identical crisis. Aditya is in Mumbai. Lakshmi is in Bengaluru. Both ran manufacturing companies. Both came to us with the same urgent request: "Help us increase sales. We need more revenue." But when we dug deeper, a different picture emerged: delayed deliveries, production errors, sourcing mistakes, and documentation chaos. Their operations were barely holding together under current demand, and they wanted to pile on more.

We gave them both the same assignment: have an honest conversation with your top five clients and ask directly about giving you more business. Aditya's largest client said it plainly: "We're not thinking of giving you more business. Not because we don't have the need; we desperately need more capacity. But you seem completely overloaded. Every delivery is a negotiation. We've quietly been building alternative suppliers." Lakshmi heard almost identical words in Bengaluru. Both companies were operating at roughly 35 per cent of actual capacity. The problem was not too little business. It was too much BUSYness, operations so error-prone and unreliable that clients were walking away while the factories sat under-utilized.

BUSYness was driving away the business.

4.f Brand Compromised

A compromised delivery experience produces a compromised brand, not through a single catastrophic failure, but through the steady accumulation of slightly-below-expectation experiences. "Good people, but you have to manage them." That phrase, you have to manage them, is the dilution of your brand, one sentence at a time.

Instead of you solving the client's problems, you've become the problem the client has to solve.

Brand damage doesn't always announce itself loudly. Sometimes it arrives in a single sentence from a procurement

officer that closes a door you didn't realise you'd been slowly, systematically shutting.

A manufacturing company in a sensitive industry had won a competitive bid, a significant order, the kind that would have opened a new tier of growth. The numbers were right. The price was competitive. They'd earned the contract on paper. Then the client's procurement team made its final assessment. The pattern they saw in the vendor's recent history; inconsistent quality, a track record of delivery delays, promises made and revised and revised again - made the decision easy. "Even though you've won the bid," the procurement officer told them, "we're not in a position to give you the order." The entire order went to a larger, more reliable competitor.

That order would have changed the company's growth trajectory. It was within reach. They had qualified for it on merit. They lost it not to a competitor's better price or superior product, but to their own compromised operational reputation.

4.g Future Compromised

There's no single story for this link, because Future Compromised isn't a moment you can point to. It's what every other link adds up to, quietly, over years.

In a High-Performance Organization, each link looks different. Recruitment is a strategic investment: the question

isn't "who's available?" but "who will help us become what we need to become?" Training is sustained, rigorous, and verified, a capability-building system, not a calendar event. Promotion follows demonstrated readiness, not tenure, and always comes with deliberate preparation for the new role. Sales brings in clients the organization can serve excellently, at margins that let it keep improving. Delivery is so consistent that it becomes the organization's most powerful sales tool. Brand is simply the accumulation of hundreds of kept promises. And the organization's future is protected by a leadership pipeline that doesn't depend on any single individual's continued presence.

An organization that has compromised recruitment, training, promotion, sales, delivery, and brand hasn't just underperformed in the present. It has mortgaged its future. The capabilities it will need to compete tomorrow aren't being built today, and a chain doesn't fail at its weakest link. It fails everywhere downstream of its weakest link.

4.h Every Manager and Supervisor as the CEO's Representative

Job titles like "supervisor" and "manager" suggest seniority and scope, but they don't describe the real job. At every level, the role is precise and demanding: to be the CEO's representative.

The CEO can't be everywhere. The supervisors and managers are everywhere. They are the culture. They are the standard. Every decision a manager makes either carries the

organization's purpose, strategy, and standards further into the world or erodes them.

A manager must know the strategy being built and the culture being created, and their specific role in both. They must make decisions the CEO would be proud to own.

That is the standard. And it starts with the CEO holding it first.

In a mid-sized manufacturing company in Rajasthan, the MD noticed that two of his plant managers were consistently making decisions that prioritised their department's convenience over the customer's experience. When he investigated, the root cause was simple: neither manager had ever been told, clearly and specifically, what decisions they were empowered to make and what standard those decisions had to meet. They were managing their departments. They were not representing the MD's vision. Once the MD held a half-day session with all twelve of his managers, not to give instructions, but to share his thinking, his priorities, and the standard he held himself to, something shifted. Within ninety days, cross-department complaints dropped by half. Not because of a new process. Because twelve people finally understood what it meant to lead on his behalf.

This is what closes the chain. A Competency Chain built link by link still depends on the people running it to see themselves as more than department heads, as the CEO's representatives, everywhere the CEO cannot be.

Once the chain is strong, the next question is whether the leader is thinking clearly enough to use it well, which is where Chapter 5 begins.

EXERCISES

Exercise 1: The Competency Chain Audit

Parameter	What should be assessed	Score (1-10)
Right recruitment	The organisation attracts and selects people who fit the role, culture, values, and capability needs; the hiring quality is improving the organisation's performance and culture.	
Onboarding and continual training	The onboarding programme accelerates productivity, cultural integration, and role clarity, and the ongoing training is improving capability and individual and team performance.	
Promotion to managerial roles	The quality, fairness, and rigour of the process used to identify and elevate employees into managerial positions; whether promoted managers actually lead teams well, drive results, and uphold culture.	
Sales focus: right customers and right deals	Whether the sales team consistently targets the right customer segments, qualifies opportunities effectively, avoids poor-fit deals, and wins business that is profitable, strategic, and sustainable.	
Reliable delivery; quality and timeliness	Is the organisation consistently delivering products or services above the promised quality level and ahead of time, whether delivery reliability strengthens customer retention, reputation, and future business?	
Brand and customer trust	The organisation is earning trust through credibility, consistency, service quality, ethical conduct, and problem resolution, strengthening its brand perception every day.	
Future outlook	The organisation's current strengths, capability depth, execution discipline, market standing, and external perception all contribute to future readiness.	

YOUR NOTES

5

Reflection

What Is Your BUSYness Hiding?

BUSYness isn't the problem. It is the solution, a remarkably effective, socially approved way of avoiding the discomfort of not knowing.

Discomfort of not knowing whether your clients value you or merely tolerate you; whether your strategy is a real strategy; whether your best people are truly committed; what your competitors understand about your market that you don't.

These are difficult to know and costly not to know. BUSYness fills the space where that discomfort would live.

The conversations that would surface real answers are slow conversations, and a BUSY organization has no patience for slowness. It doesn't have a shortage of information; it has a shortage of the stillness in which information becomes understanding.

5.a Version 1.0, Version 2.0, and the Discipline

When we work with organizations on long-term transformation, we ask them to label their current business as Version 1.0 and the business they're trying to build as Version 2.0.

The 1.0 business will consume forty-eight hours a day if you let it. Version 2.0 won't happen, won't go beyond a good idea, unless you create dedicated time for it and protect that time.

As Dr. Otto Scharmer of MIT says in his book on Theory U, the first transformation for creating a new reality is Transforming Perception. It precedes transforming self and transforming action, and it cannot be skipped.

This is also why ROAR begins with Reflect, not Run. Everything else in this model depends on whether this first movement is genuine.

Theory U makes one more distinction worth holding: the difference between discussion, debate, and dialogue. In most meetings, people either perform alignment or advocate for positions.

A BUSY organization has plenty of discussion and debate, but almost no dialogue.

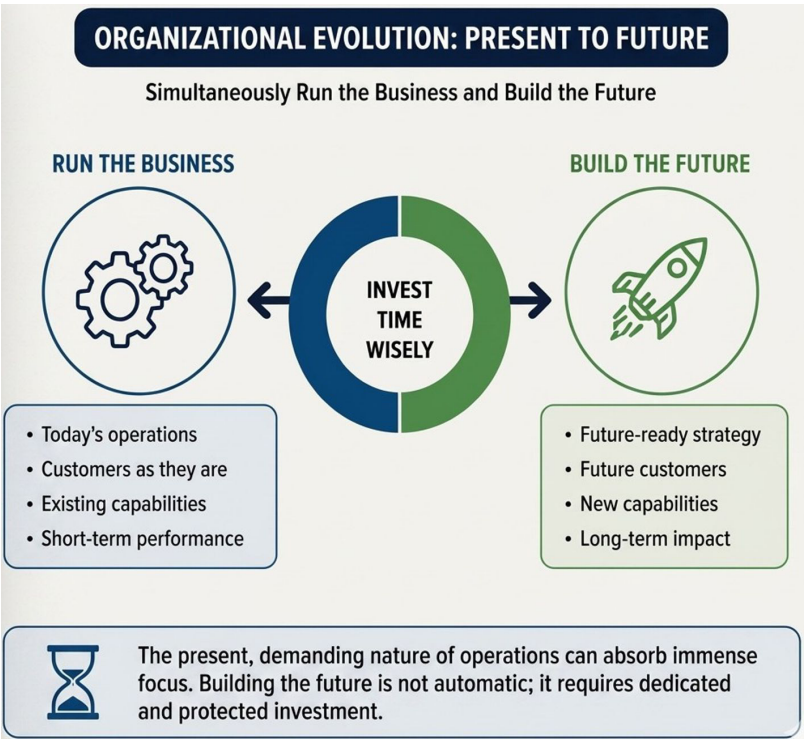
Mr. Pandya, the Managing Director of a mid-sized manufacturing company headquartered in Mumbai, India,

made a decision that his leadership team initially received with scepticism. He announced that two days every month would be dedicated entirely to learning and reflection, no client meetings, no operational reviews, no routine work.

The first few sessions felt uncomfortable. Leaders who were accustomed to non-stop activities had to pause, look, and reflect on their company, the market, and their collective mindset. Since some of them had attended our workshops earlier, they trusted the process. We encouraged them to collect data and see the market with fresh eyes, question their positioning in the market, their business plans, challenges, and opportunities. Mr. Pandya was in all the sessions himself, curious, engaged, asking thoughtful questions, sharing real concerns, and encouraging the team toward open and honest communication. He built a dialogue culture where everyone spoke, and everyone was heard.

What emerged was not visible in any operational meeting. The leadership team began to see, with real clarity, that the organization's next stage would need a different kind of leadership than the one that had brought it this far. They would need capabilities the existing team didn't fully have. They also realised they had been benchmarking themselves against the best in India, not the best in the world, while wanting to compete against the global players. They acknowledged that their understanding of their most important customers was shallower than they had assumed.

That insight led to one of the most consequential decisions the company made in years: a deliberate, structured effort to bring in high-calibre external leadership for certain key roles instead of pushing all the responsibilities to the current people and hoping that they would learn on the job. Certain capabilities were not there in the organization, and it wasn't appropriate to expect current people to somehow be able to do things that required different experience and exposure.



Most leaders try to build Version 2.0 using Version 1.0 thinking.

Research consistently finds that more than half of the average week goes to activities that produce motion without progress (Asana, 2024). Deep, original thinking, the kind that produces real competitive advantage, requires protected time.

5.b The Gap Between You and What Your Clients Actually Think

Your dashboards show a lot of data. They don't show what your clients think about you, whether they see you as a partner or a vendor.

Most organizations mistake transaction history for relationship depth. They know what a client buys and what they pay. They don't know what that client's business is trying to become, what keeps their leadership team awake at night, or what would make them leave them for the competition OR sometimes in-house options. Assumptions, held long enough without examination, become beliefs. Beliefs, over time, become the walls of a box you can no longer see beyond.

Diagnostic question:

Take the list of your top ten clients. With how many of them has your leadership team had a real conversation within the last year, not a service review, not a sales call, but a conversation about their business, their pressures, and their future? When did you last hear, directly and without filtering, what frustrates them about working with you?

5.c The Absence of Real Thinking

Reacting is fast. Thinking is slow, which is precisely why a BUSY organization has so little of it.

Have your leaders been trained to think? There are dozens of thinking models leaders can develop.

We recommend adding First Principles Thinking and Systems Thinking to your toolkit.

5.d Whether your best people have already left, mentally

In a BUSY organization, commitment and compliance look identical. Your people show up, hit deadlines, say the right things, and some of them have already decided, quietly, that their future isn't here.

Hint: Conduct empathy walks and stakeholder interviews (ref. Theory U) with all your key people and several others.

5.e The Gap Between Your Purpose and the Frontline

Chapter 2 named this gap. Here is how to measure it in your own organization today.

Ask people across the organization, at random, what the purpose of the organization is, and how their work contributes to it.

The responses and the silences will tell you a great deal.

5.f The Age of Your Assumptions

Every organization develops assumptions about its market, its customers, its competitors, and its own capabilities. Most of these were valid once.

The question is whether they are still valid and whether alternative perspectives exist. An organization too busy to challenge its own assumptions ends up running a past version of itself in a market that has already moved on. The gap between those two places doesn't stay fixed. It widens every year you don't look.

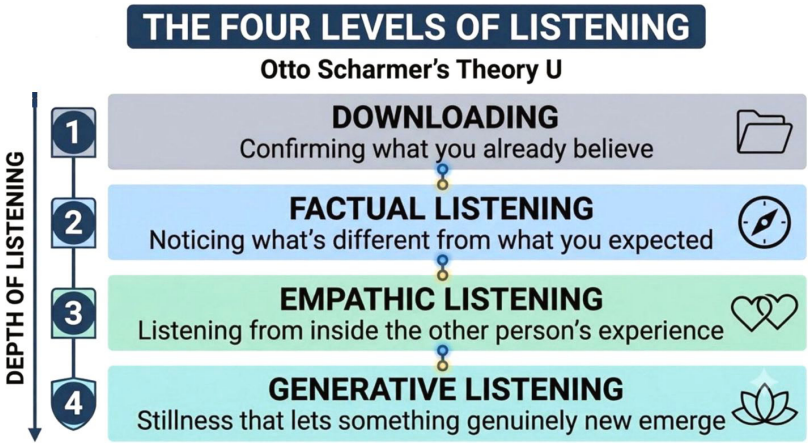
Hint: Ask the leadership team to spend a month studying the market, meeting key stakeholders, and surfacing contradictory data, information that challenges your current assumptions about yourself, your competition, your industry, and the future.

5.g The Listening Practice

Four levels of listening

Dr. Otto Scharmer's work describes four levels, and most organizational conversations never get past the first.

Downloading: You already know what they're going to say, so you listen just long enough to confirm it. This is the default mode of habitual listening without much conscious effort: reconfirming what you already believe, often while mentally composing your reply.



Factual listening: You notice what's actually different from what you expected. This requires setting your assumption aside long enough to register a fact that contradicts it.

Empathic listening: You listen from inside the other person's experience instead of your own. You stop evaluating what they're saying and start sensing why it matters to them.

Generative listening: You listen from a kind of stillness that lets something genuinely new emerge, something never fully articulated before the conversation began. This is rare, and it cannot be rushed.

5.h What We See When the Noise Stops

When a leadership team looks at its industry with fresh eyes, generative listening applied to data they had stopped really examining, a new world opens up. Most have plans, not a real strategy. When leaders engage with the discipline of deep

strategic thinking, mapping Customer Segments, Product Portfolios, Channels, and Geographic Presence, new possibilities become real, not aspirational.

This is what BUSYness hides. A world that becomes visible only when the noise stops.

EXERCISES, CHAPTER 5: REFLECTION

Read the chapter once more and make your notes.

YOUR NOTES

6

Ownership

This is the Own move of ROAR. You have seen the limitations of a BUSY culture. Now you choose, without excuses, to take responsibility for what you have seen.

The Two Cultures: BUSY vs. High Performance

"Does your organization depend on follow-up and reminders to get things done?"

If follow-up messages are a normal part of your week, if status chases are expected, if reminders are built into the workflow, if the question "did you follow up on that?" is a standard part of how things move forward, then you're living in a BUSY culture.

A reminder culture is an accountability tax

Follow-up is not coordination; it is compensation for missing ownership. Commitments are enforced, not owned, and the organization runs on surveillance rather than trust.

6.a How Follow-Up Cultures Accumulate

Nobody designed a follow-up culture deliberately. It accumulated, one loose promise at a time, one missed deadline absorbed without consequence, layer on layer until chasing became the rhythm of the organization.

In teams where accountability is genuinely owned, follow-up messages are rarely needed. In teams where it isn't, chasing people and deadlines becomes the most played game in town.

6.b The Two Cultures, Side by Side

- **Customers.**

In a BUSY culture, customers are a transaction. Nobody is immersed in the customers' world.

In a High-Performance culture, the customers' long-term objectives are not just managed; they are genuinely understood. Their dreams and challenges are studied continuously. Leaders in a high-performance Organization, stop asking how to get more business and instead ask how to partner with the customers and serve them at the core.

- **Accountability.**

In a BUSY culture, accountability is enforced. Work advances only after checking.

In a high-performance culture, accountability is owned. Commitments are explicit.

- **Standards.**

In high-performance companies, standards are non-negotiable.

Once you lower the standard, you've decided who you're becoming.

- **The Future.**

In a BUSY culture, the future arrives as disruption, and the organization scrambles to respond. The High-Performance organization sees disruption early and moves first, because it is always scanning the landscape and looking for the emerging future, rather than firefighting the present.

- **Why People Show Up.**

In a BUSY culture, people are doing a job. Delivering at a level way below the collective capability, because that's the level the culture has calibrated to. Again, a transactional relationship.

In a High-Performance Organization, people are part of something they genuinely value.

The gap between a BUSY culture and a High-Performance one is measurable. The finding from Chapter 2 bears repeating here: 70% of a team's engagement is tied to the quality of the immediate manager (Gallup, 2025). The global employee engagement average is just 20%. That kind of engagement level is the product of a BUSY organization, not in sync with an inspiring purpose.

6.c NFR: No Follow-Up Required

NFR – No Follow-Up Required is the standard that separates BUSY cultures from High-Performance ones.

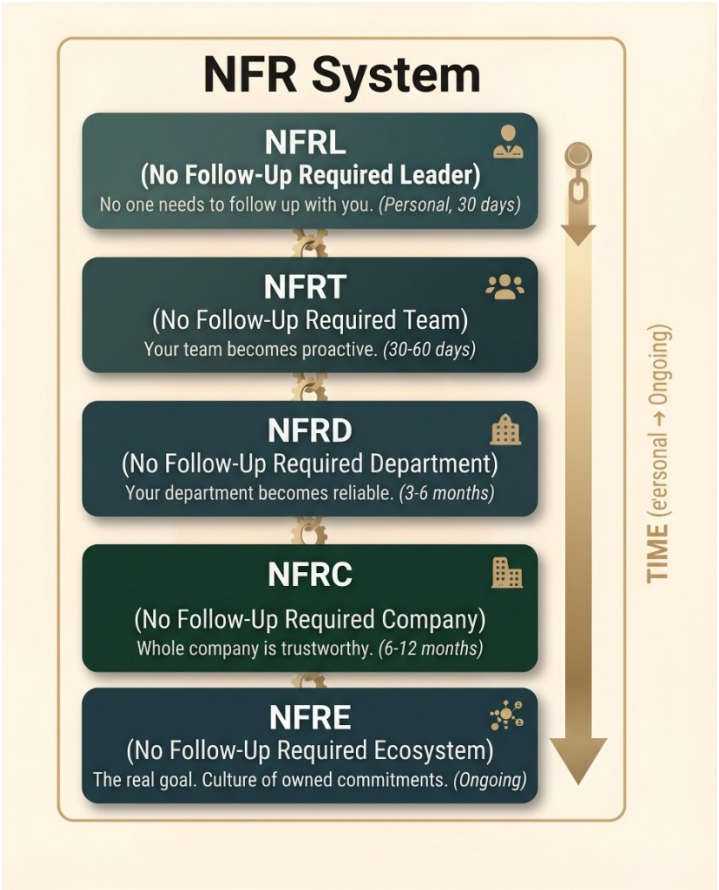
No Follow-Up Required means in your organization, a commitment made is a commitment honoured. Leaders and teams operate with such clarity, ownership, and integrity that no follow-ups are required. People will commit thoughtfully, but once committed, it will be done. In case of breakdowns, pro-active communication is the norm.

The evidence from these organizations confirms that once the leader personally models the standard, something in the organization's nervous system begins to change.

Within months, the evidence from these organizations confirmed something nobody had predicted: a significant increase in teamwork and mutual respect. When accountability becomes the norm, trust follows.

If organizations stop chasing and start being NFR, they free up eight to twelve hours per person per week. That is a full working day returned to strategic work, relationship building, deep thinking, the very things that a BUSY organization can never find time for.

The NFR System works through five phases:



1. **NFRL** – No Follow-Up Required Leader. If no one needs to follow up with you, you're certified as an NFRL.
2. **NFRT** – NFR Team – Your team becomes proactive in communication, and no follow-up is required.
3. **NFRD** – NFR Department – Your department becomes reliable.
4. **NFRC** – NFR Company – The whole company becomes trustworthy.

5. **NFRE** – NFR Ecosystem – The real goal.

6.d Culture Can Change

On 4 February 2014, Satya Nadella became CEO of Microsoft. The culture he inherited was what he called "know-it-all", siloed departments protecting turf, leaders exhausted by internal politics, teams falling behind on every major platform shift (mobile, cloud, social). The company that had dominated personal computing was becoming irrelevant in the new world. Nadella's first major declaration as CEO shocked many. It wasn't a product announcement, a restructuring plan, or a financial target. He declared, "Our ability to change our culture is the leading indicator of our future success." Culture first. The strategy would follow.

The cultural shift from "know-it-all" to "learn-it-all" had to come first. Only then did the commercial transformation become possible.

The numbers tell the story: Microsoft's market cap grew from $300 billion when Nadella took over to approximately $3 trillion by 2024, a tenfold increase. Revenue grew nearly 3x. The stock price grew roughly 10x.

Those numbers, though, are the outcome, not the cause. The cause was a CEO who understood that cultural transformation is the prerequisite for commercial transformation, that no strategy survives a culture that cannot sustain it. Transform the culture. Everything else can be built on that foundation.

Building the NFR Culture: Practical Leadership Behaviours
What follows are not abstract principles. Each one describes a concrete change in behaviour that, when practised consistently by the leader first, begins to shift the organization's relationship with commitment.

- Slow down the making of commitments and the accepting of commitments.

Make it a conscious activity. Ensure complete understanding on both sides of what's being committed to, why it's important, how it fits the bigger picture, what the process is for delivering it, and the timelines, support and resources required.

- Create mutually agreed updates or check-ins.
- For large and complex tasks, create timely progress check-ins.

All of these are on the foundation of Shared Purpose, Aligned Strategy, Respect in Relationships, Culture of Accountability, and Discipline of Proactive Communication.

EXERCISES

Exercise: The Follow-Up Audit

Step 1 – Your Personal Count (3 minutes)

Answer these three questions, based on today only:

1. How many follow-ups did you send to get something done? *(messages, emails, calls to colleagues, vendors, board members, etc.)*

2. How many follow-ups did you receive where someone chased you?
3. Roughly how many total minutes did those follow-ups take you today? *(Estimate: 1 minute per short message, 5 minutes per call or longer exchange.)*
4. Write your three numbers:
5. Sent: _ | Received: _ | Minutes: _

Step 2 – Multiply to See the Real Cost

Now calculate: "If I spend _ minutes/day on follow-ups, that is __ hours/year."

"If my entire team does the same, how many team-hours per year are we consuming on follow-ups?"

"What high-value work could I (or they) do with those hours instead?"

"This is not just lost time. It's lost focus, increased stress, and fragmented attention across my day."

Step 3 – One CEO-Level Change (2 minutes)

Write one specific change you will make in the next 7 days to reduce follow-up waste at your level. Examples:

- "I will make thoughtful commitments and ensure each one is honoured without anyone needing to follow up."
- Write your commitment:

YOUR NOTES

7

Leadership Creates

Leadership creates. It brings new realities into being: a culture, a standard, a future that, before the leader chose to build it, existed only as potential.

The organizations that truly transform are always led by someone who has made this choice. Choosing to stop managing the existing reality and start creating a new one.

John Kotter's research at Harvard confirms this: most organizations are overmanaged and underled.

Talent isn't the problem, and neither is management competence. Leadership requires a different orientation: the deliberate choice to create rather than optimise. Organizations rarely name that difference explicitly enough to develop it.

7.a Three Comfort Zones Leaders Must Break

Comfort zone 1: Past Ways of Working.

The method that built you is now limiting you. The processes, habits, and structures that produced the organization's early success have now become the walls. The organization defends the method instead of serving the mission. It has built an immunity to change.

Robert Kegan and Lisa Lahey's 'Immunity to Change' (2009) describes this pattern in detail.

Some of the common responses under the corporate immunity to change are:

1. This is how we have always done it.
   Worth asking: Does past success guarantee future success?

2. We are too busy right now.
   Worth asking: Is operational urgency truly more important than strategic improvement right now?

3. We tried this before, and it didn't work.
   Worth asking: Does one earlier attempt settle the question for good?

4. The market is different for us.
   Worth asking: Are we certain we are the exception?

5. Our customers haven't asked for it.
   Worth asking: Can customers always articulate what they will need next?

6. Let's form a team to study it.
   Worth asking: Does involving more people always produce a better decision?

The current system is uncomfortable, but change feels riskier. Organizations often choose familiar inefficiency over unfamiliar improvement.

Comfort Zone 2: Silos and Hierarchy.

The hierarchy that provided clarity at an earlier stage now slows decision-making and distances leadership from reality. The silos that increased focus and productivity now prevent the cross-functional collaboration that the next stage demands.

Production and Sourcing are in a permanent cold war. R&D operates on a different calendar, one where urgency hasn't yet been invented. Sales sells what doesn't exist and calls it optimism. Customer Service apologises for what it didn't cause. Finance tracks numbers that Operations has stopped believing in. They aren't different departments. They are different organizations, sharing a name, a building, and very little else. The only thing moving freely across these invisible borders is the blame.

The organization is structured for the company it was, not the company it needs to become.

A trading company we worked with had built a large, experienced leadership team and a reputation for exceptional client service. For years, their model was the source of their strength: each business unit operated as a separate SBU, with its own leadership, its own client relationships, and its own ego. The autonomy created accountability. It worked well.

Until it didn't. When we began working with them, a pattern that nobody had named had been running for years. Multiple SBUs were independently approaching the same clients, each pitching their own product range, each managing their own relationship, each unaware of what the other was doing. The client would receive three calls from the same company in a week, from three different people, for three different products. The internal cost in duplicated effort was significant. The external signal to the client was fractured. The SBU model, which had given the company agility, had also given it invisibility from itself.

There was a second, deeper problem. The company's working style was built around serving individual clients with excellence. And they did; their client satisfaction was genuine. But because every relationship was managed individually, the company had never developed the discipline of working on customer segments. They were equally attentive to every client regardless of strategic fit or

scale potential. The result was an organization that was genuinely loved by many clients but had never built the scale that concentrated focus on high-potential segments would have created.

The SBU model was not wrong when it was designed. The individual-client approach was not wrong when it was built. Both were exactly right, for the stage of the organization that then existed. It was a success that had outlived its context. Breaking it required the leadership team to acknowledge that the structure they were proud of was now the ceiling they were bumping against. It was understandably difficult initially.

Comfort Zone 3: Past Success

Is your organization using past success as a *seed* to grow from, as a foundation to build on, OR

As a benchmark that has shaped the limited expectations of the future?

In a recent case of an organizational turnaround, a new CEO of a global organization launched a large initiative for deep strategic thinking and direction setting. He involved 500 leaders across the organization in making real choices about where the organization would play and how it would win. The process was uncomfortable by design.

The outcome was not just a strategy document. It was **500 leaders** who had been inside the creation of a new reality,

who understood the choices that had been made and why, and who could carry that understanding into every room the CEO can't reach.

Companies that proactively disrupt their own business models before being disrupted externally consistently outperform those that wait. Organizations that break their own paradigms are those that lead.

The companies that protect their business models, even when the need for change is visible, eventually get broken by someone else.

7.b Creating Time for Creating the Future

One of the most practical expressions of the choice to create rather than just manage is the protection of time for creation.

The Managing Director and a fellow Director of a client company in Karnataka, India, made a deliberate, structural decision: one full day per week, dedicated entirely to creating the future, not managing the routine.

A leadership team of a Mumbai-based client made a similar commitment and has been progressively moving towards three dedicated days per week, every alternate day, for building the future.

These are working CEOs, MDs, Directors, and Business Heads with full calendars and real pressures. What separates them from organizations still trapped in BUSYness has

nothing to do with how much capacity they have. It comes down to intention.

7.c You Can't Delegate the Momentum of Change

Every leader who has tried to drive organizational transformation discovers this, usually the hard way.

The moment you step back, the organization drifts back. Steadily, reliably, the gravitational pull of the familiar reclaims the space the leader vacated.

You can share the leadership. You can build a team that carries it with you. What you can't delegate is its energy, not until the culture itself has been transformed.

7.d From Company to Ecosystem

Most people build businesses; good leaders build organizations, but the extraordinary ones build ecosystems.

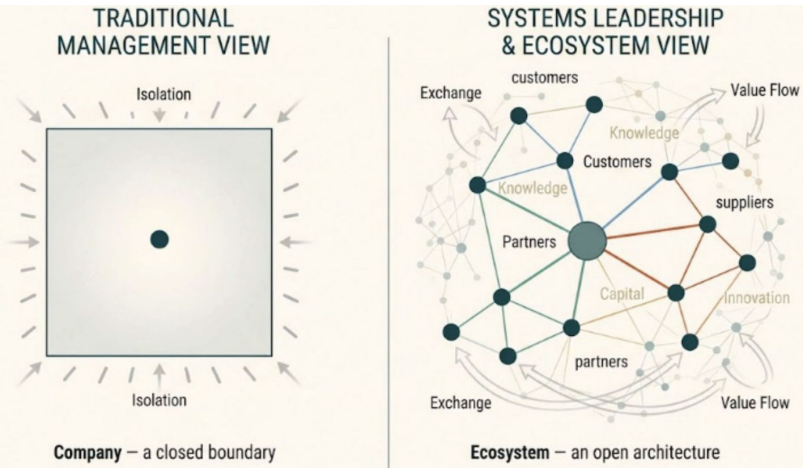
An ecosystem mindset redraws the boundaries. Customers become co-creators of value, not merely transactions to be managed. Suppliers and service providers become collaborators in expanding the space rather than adversaries to be defended against.

The question shifts from "how do we win our share of the market?" to "how do we co-create a larger one?"

An organization with a healthy ecosystem doesn't just resist disruption. It is creating disruption to all those companies

that are fighting as individual companies. Eco- systems will win against individual companies almost all the time.

Consider an educational institution that could have remained a well-run school. Instead, it built an ecosystem, franchisees, specialist coaching providers, sports academies, ed-tech organizations, teacher development partnerships, and parent education programmes. Each partnership expanded the institution's reach without requiring it to own and control everything. The school became a platform. The platform became a movement.



7.e The Choice Is Made Every Day

The leader's choice isn't made in a single dramatic moment of courage. It is made in every meeting, every conversation, every decision about what to accept and what to challenge, whether you ask the creative question or the operational one.

Whether you defend the existing process or question whether the process is still serving the mission.

Every morning, two options appear.

Option One: Manage the existing reality. Protect what worked before.

Option Two: Create the new reality. Break the existing paradigm.

A leader who makes option two daily, not in one dramatic moment, but in a hundred ordinary ones, produces a High-Performance organization.

EXERCISES

Exercise 1: The Creation vs. Management Audit

For one week, keep a simple running log of your significant decisions and conversations and update them in this kind of table. Rate M for Managing the Current Reality and C for Creating the New Reality.

Date	Decision	M	C
	Total		

MIRROR QUESTION

How many times this week did you choose the familiar path over the one that would have required you to build something new?

YOUR NOTES

8

Assert the Standard

This is the Assert move of ROAR. You have seen, you have owned. Now you set non-negotiable standards for yourself first, then for every level of the organization.

The organization doesn't do what the CEO says.
It does what the CEO does.

8.a The Standard the CEO Sets is the Standard the organization Holds.

Edgar Schein's research at MIT established that culture is shaped by what leaders pay attention to, measure, and react to. Not what they say but by what they *do*, consistently, under pressure, when it would be easier to let something slide.

Schein's core argument is that culture is ultimately created, embedded, evolved, and manipulated by leaders. When leaders can't change culture, leaders must be changed. (Schein, 2010)

8.b Ego-centric vs. Eco-centric

Ego-centric leaders demand compliance. They enforce through fear. People perform when watched. Culture ends or reverts when they leave.

Eco-centric leaders demand excellence. They inspire through the standards they hold first. People perform because they believe. The culture outlasts their tenure.



The contrast between the two plays out in every leadership engagement we run.

Dr. Raghavan commanded the room. Brilliant mind. Encyclopaedic knowledge of his industry. Ambitious vision for his group of companies. For two decades, he had driven his entire conglomerate in the directions he saw fit, and mostly, those directions had been right. Revenue grew. Market share expanded. Awards accumulated. Something was missing, though. In our early conversations with his leadership team, the same phrase kept emerging: "We execute his vision." The CEOs reporting to him were capable, experienced leaders reduced to high-level executors. They implemented it. They didn't lead. Dr. Raghavan was the brain. Everyone else was hands.

The breakthrough came in month four of our engagement. Dr. Raghavan was in our leadership programme, surrounded not by his own team but by other CEOs and chairpersons facing similar challenges. In a particularly intense session on ego-centric versus eco- centric leadership, he went quiet. That evening, he called us. "I just realised something painful," he said. "I've built an organization completely dependent on me. When I'm in the room, decisions get made. When I'm not, everything waits. I thought I was being a strong leader. I was actually being a bottleneck." The shift started in him first, the willingness to move from command-and-control to collective creation, from being the smartest person in the room to building a room full of smart people

who could challenge him. Then it rippled outward. He and his leadership team began practicing co-creation. Real co-creation, not performative consultation. The CEO of each group company became genuinely empowered to lead, not just execute. They, in turn, began empowering their own teams. Decisions that used to take weeks now took days, because they didn't need to route through Dr. Raghavan anymore. The organization started transforming, not because one brilliant person was driving it, but because everyone now owned its future.

Contrast this with another group CEO, Sunil, headquartered in North India. Equally intelligent. Highly accomplished. Deeply ambitious for his companies. When he attended our programmes, he absorbed every framework with intellectual precision. He could discuss Otto Scharmer's Theory U, Roger Martin's strategic choices, Edgar Schein's culture models, all of it, fluently, impressively. He sent his entire leadership team to our programmes. "They need this," he told us. "They need to learn how to think strategically, how to lead, and how to make better decisions."

He didn't change. Not one degree. He learned the language, but not the lesson.

The difference between them had nothing to do with intelligence or ambition. Dr. Raghavan was willing to examine his own behaviour as the root of the problem. Sunil always located the source of the problem in others. The result

was an organization of capable, frustrated leaders, with ideas they were afraid to propose.

8.c The Four Non-Negotiables

These are critical elements of the CEO's personal promise to the organization. Each one changes the architecture of how the organization functions.

Non-Negotiable 1: No Follow-Up Required.

The NFR standard is detailed in Chapter 6.

Non-Negotiable 2: World-Class Best Practices in Every Function.

Every function must operate at the standard of global best practice. Not "good for our size." What the world's best organizations have demonstrated is possible. One needs a serious effort to customise the best practices and bring them into the organization.

Rajiv entered the conference room for day one of his induction at a premium training company in India, expecting the usual: HR paperwork, an office tour, maybe a few PowerPoint slides. What he got instead was a shock. "Welcome to boot camp," the training director said with a friendly smile. "For the next 21 days, you will eat, breathe, and dream of training excellence. Content mastery. Delivery technique. Participant psychology. Impact measurement. You will not stand in front of a single paying client until our certification panel says you're ready." Excellence wasn't a goal there. It was the entry requirement.

It didn't stop after induction. Quarterly audits. Surprise observations. Ongoing re-certification. Rajiv, three years in and now one of the firm's top trainers, still gets nervous before his quarterly review. "The day I stop being nervous," he says, "is the day I've started coasting. That's not allowed here." Nobody on the team experienced this rigour as burdensome. It was simply normal, the price of being the best.

That standard lived inside one function. Non-Negotiable Two demands the same rigour, deliberately, in every function, not just the one a particular leader happens to care about.

Deferring development doesn't save money. It accumulates a competency deficit that presents its bill eventually, with interest.

Non-Negotiable 3: Break the Silo.

Departmentalism is an organization's cancer.

In a Karnataka-based technology company, the weekly leadership meeting had become a battlefield. "Sales promises timelines that we can't deliver," snapped Arjun from Engineering. "Engineering takes three months for what should take three weeks," shot back Meera from Sales. Operations blamed Finance. Finance blamed everybody. The CEO, Kumar, finally stood up and drew a circle on the whiteboard. "This circle is our company. We are all inside it. When you attack another department, you're attacking yourself." "We're either one team, or we're nothing." That conversation was the beginning of a painful but necessary transformation.

Three truths every department-level leader in the organization must know, internalise, and live by:

1. If you're married to the department, you're divorced from the company.
2. Departments aren't real; they're created merely as a work-distribution mechanism.
3. There are no successful departments in a failed organization.

The CEO must demand structurally supported collaboration across every function, refusing to allow territorial behaviour regardless of seniority.

Non-Negotiable 4: People as Source, Not Resource.

In a High-Performance Organization, the leader's relationship with people is not transactional; it is generative. The leader creates conditions in which people co-create beyond their current capability. This is the most personal of the four non-negotiables. It begins in the leader's own assumptions about what people are for.

Global research confirms that organizations investing significantly in people development see 11% greater profitability (Deloitte, 2023) and are twice as likely to be in the top quartile of financial performance.

This effort goes beyond the traditional HR function's role. It is the CEO's personal operating standard.

The Managing Director of an Indian multinational we worked with understood this distinction at the deepest level. He faced a situation that most leaders in his position would have handled through a combination of restructuring, new appointments, and a revised strategy document. He chose a different path: before announcing any structural change, before shifting any business model element, before redirecting a single priority, he invested eight months in developing his core leadership team.

Not a one-day offsite. Eight months of deliberate leadership development, building the mindset, capability, and shared language that transformed a collective realisation, not an announcement.

Only after that foundation was established did he bring the leadership team together to co-create the alignment for the fundamental changes the business needed: to its model, its structure, and its priorities for the future.

8.d The Personal Standard: Share It & Live It.

These four non-negotiables are sustained by one personal practice that the CEO must maintain without exception.

Start every meeting by connecting to the organizational purpose and referring to it as the source from which every decision flows. Talk strategy the same way: the living filter for where we play and how we win, applied visibly to every choice you make. Use this process as a truing mechanism, a GO / NO-GO check for every decision.

When the CEO applies this discipline consistently, the behaviour propagates without instruction. Leaders at every level begin testing their own proposals against purpose and strategy before bringing them forward, having internalised the filter rather than waiting to be told to apply it.

The framework is now complete. What remains is the work of building it into a structure that outlasts any individual's sustained attention.

Chapter 9 addresses exactly that: the twelve-phase implementation plan for building a High-Performance organization that runs without you having to hold it together personally.

EXERCISES

Exercise 1: The Personal Covenant

THE FOUR NON-NEGOTIABLES

Review the standard below. Then, in the table that follows, write down one visible change you will make in the next seven days that your team would notice without being told about it.

THE STANDARD

1. **No Follow-Up Required (NFR)**
2. **World-Class Best Practices in Every Function**
3. **Break the Silo**
4. **People as Source, Not Resource**

MY AUDIT

Non-Negotiable	Visible change in the next 7 days
Non-Negotiable 1 No Follow-Up Required	

Non-Negotiable	Visible change in the next 7 days
Non-Negotiable 2 World-Class Best Practices in Every Function	

Non-Negotiable	Visible change in the next 7 days
Non-Negotiable 3 Break the Silo	

Non-Negotiable	Visible change in the next 7 days
Non-Negotiable 4 People as Source, Not Resource	

YOUR NOTES

9

Build

This is the Run move of ROAR. Twelve phases of world-class implementation. Beginning of an HPO – High-Performance organization.

You have reflected on the current reality. You have owned up courageously. You have asserted the standard for yourself.

Now you build. You KILL BUSYness and Build a High-Performance organization.

This chapter is a holistic implementation guide.

First: The first four phases can be accomplished in less than 90 days.

The remaining eight phases will take approximately 12 months.

Part One: The First 90 Days

The first four phases are about you and your leadership team creating the right environment in which you can build the HPO.

Phase 1, Educate Everyone on NFR (No Follow-Up Required)

Duration: 1–2 weeks.

MD/ CEO personally train the leadership team; cascaded by each leader to their own team.

No Follow-Up Required was defined in Chapter 6. Ensure that every single person in the organization has heard it directly from a leader, in person, not by memo.

Walk your leadership team through the four disciplines that make NFR real rather than aspirational:

a. systemic elimination of follow-up loops,
b. formalised service-level agreements in place of vague dependence,
c. calendar-driven accountability instead of reactive chasing, and
d. thoughtful commitments, promises made only when delivery is genuinely possible.

Have every leader run the Follow-Up Audit from Chapter 6.

This phase is complete when every leader in the organization has understood how much personal and organizational time

and energy is wasted when they are not NFR, when their team is not NFR, and when the whole company is not NFR.

Phase 2, Implement NFR for Yourself and Your Leadership Team

Duration: 30 days for the first certification cycle, then continued monthly thereafter.

Owner: CEO first, then every member of the leadership team.

Re-look at your SLAs(Service Level Agreements) and commitments. Withdraw from those commitments and change those SLAs that are not adding value to the organization.

Certification as an NFR Leader (NFRL) is monthly, not a one-time badge. The standard is simple and unforgiving: every promise and every SLA was kept, and wherever a breakdown occurred, the leader was in timely, proactive communication about it before anyone had to ask. NFRL does not mean never breaking a commitment. It means either you are reliable in keeping your commitments fully, or whenever there is a breakdown, you are reliable in communicating proactively to all the concerned persons and managing the fallouts of the breakdown.

The platform at www.KILLBUSYness.com will have the link to the resource centre that carries the full workbook, the charter, and the certification standard for your leadership team.

This phase is complete when the entire leadership team has completed one full certification cycle, and NFRL has become a known, monthly rhythm, not a launch event.

Continue to develop NFRT, NFRD, and NFRC. And manage this till the time NFR becomes part of the organization's DNA. Continue to manage this for a long period of time. At least two to three years.

Phase 3, Project Whitespace: Empty Your Calendar by 50%

Duration: 2–3 weeks.

Owner: CEO, Senior Leadership Team, and all People Managers, supported by HR.

Before you add a single new initiative, purpose work, strategy work, or redesign work, you must first make room for it. It is difficult to commit to new things, even if they are good ones, when you have a full calendar and are already struggling with BUSYness.

Start with your calendar. Sort all activities into three categories: work that genuinely created value, work that existed to manage the absence of trust (status checks, chasing, re-explaining), and work that was simply habitual, meetings that happen because they have always happened, not because they are still needed.

Cut all those things that are not a top priority. Cut that which genuinely creates the least value for the organization.

Guide the leaders to do the same.

Protect the freed time immediately. Block it in the calendar before BUSYness reclaims it.

This phase is complete when every leader on the team has verifiably freed approximately 50% of their calendar and that time is protected for deep work on the future, culture, strategy, talent transformation, and execution.

Phase 4, The Sensing Journey: Deep Connection, Sensing & Learning

Duration: 30 days.

Owner: CEO, Senior Leadership Team, and all People Managers.

Each leader commits to having deep listening conversations with staff members across levels and functions, client representatives, industry experts, key vendors, and partners.

Deep Listening, like the kind described in Chapter 5, moves past downloading to factual, empathic, and generative listening, where new data, new perspectives, new relationships, and new possibilities could emerge.

Capture what is learned in every conversation and then reflect on those notes later on.

Part Two: The Build

The first ninety days cleared up the ground. Now we create the foundation for building a purpose-driven, strategy-focused HPO (High-Performance Organization).

Phase 5, Articulate or Reconnect with Purpose

Duration: 4–6 weeks.

Owner: CEO, supported by the Senior Leadership Team.

Some organizations need to discover their purpose for the first time. Others need to reconnect and deepen their relationship with an existing one.

Use the Purpose Draft exercise from Chapter 2, now run with real data: what did the Sensing Journey reveal about what your clients actually value, what your people actually believe, and what the organization is actually for, beneath what the mission statement says? Run the Purpose Translation Test from the same chapter across the leadership team and a cross-section of the frontline, and look honestly at where the answers diverge.

A purpose drafted in a conference room and a purpose tested against what thirty real conversations just revealed are not the same exercise. Do the second one.

This phase is complete when the leadership team has a purpose statement that defines the organization's reason for existence and guides all organizational decisions.

Phase 6, Study Competitive Strategy, Build an Extraordinary One

Duration: 6–8 weeks.

Owner: CEO, supported by the Senior Leadership Team.

With purpose clarified, return to the three questions from Chapter 3: which customer segments, which of their needs, and what creates a long-term advantage no competitor can easily copy, and this time, answer them rigorously along with your core team.

Study your competitors in-depth. Use what the Sensing Journey revealed as a starting point.

If you are interested, use Roger Martin and A G Lafley's 5-choice cascade from their book – Playing to Win.

This phase is complete when the leadership team can state what their Winning Aspiration is, where they are going to play, and how they are going to win.

Phase 7, Train the Leaders

Duration: 6–8 weeks, run parallel with Phase 8.

Owner: CEO, supported by HR.

Senior leaders need to be trained in Organization Design and Organization Transformation. Doing the OD work without the right preparation tends to reproduce the old structure with new labels and triggers corporate immunity to change.

This phase is complete when the leadership team can train others in the connection between purpose, strategy, organizational structure, performance management, talent management, and every function in the organization.

Phase 8, Redesign the organization in Sync with Strategy

Duration: 8–10 weeks.

Owner: CEO, with the Senior Leadership Team.

Structure follows Strategy.

The job of the Strategy is to make your organization unique in the eyes of the customer.

The job of the organizational structure is to help you design and execute the strategy and create a High Performance Organization (HPO).

This phase is complete when the organization's structure is designed to increase the maximum effectiveness of the organization, leverage its strengths, execute its strategy, and build a foundation for lasting success.

We recommend using Strategy Maps and Balanced Score Cards in the right way, i.e., use them to articulate the strategy, then execute it, and later use it for performance management. These were created by Dr. Robert Kaplan and Dr. David Norton.

Some companies use it only for performance management. We think that is a gross underutilisation of the opportunity of these tools.

Phase 9, Redesign the Performance Management System in Sync with Strategy

Duration: 6–8 weeks.

Owner: CEO and HR, implemented by Business Heads.

What gets measured and rewarded is what actually happens, regardless of what the strategy document says.

A new structure sitting on top of an old performance system is an assured disaster.

In this phase, individual and team performance are in sync with the corporate strategy scorecard and the departmental strategy scorecard.

This phase is complete when every employee can see how they contribute specifically to the departmental strategy and the corporate strategy.

Phase 10, Train and Develop People at Every Level

Duration: Ongoing

Owner: HR, supported by Business Heads.

This phase builds the capability of everyone across the organization.

Use the Competency Chain Audit from Chapter 4 to identify the sharpest gaps: recruitment, onboarding, promotion readiness, sales discipline, and delivery consistency. Build

training tied to those specific gaps, not a generic annual calendar.

The tools that help in this phase include:

- Role-based competency framework (RCF), Peer-level Competency Assessment
- RCF-based Talent Management System
- Action Learning, Application-oriented training and development

And some more.

Phase 11, Put Systems in Place

Duration: 8–12 weeks, largely in parallel with Phase 10.

Owner: Senior Leadership Team, supported by HR and IT.

This is the phase that answers the question Chapter 8 closed with: how do you build all of this into a structure that runs without you having to hold it together personally?

Install the infrastructure for every function:

- Policies & Practices
- Work Processes & Service Level Agreements
- Decision Frameworks
- Knowledge Management Systems
- CRM and other IT backbone
- Dashboards and Management System
- Review & Reflection Mechanisms

- Feet in the Field – Leaders meeting key stakeholders in their environments.

A standard built into the infrastructure survives the leader's absence. A standard that lives only in the leader's attention is not yet a system.

Phase 12, Prototype, Prototype, Prototype

Duration: Ongoing.

Owner: Business Heads, within their respective functions.

Every decision is a prototype. Every policy or process is a prototype. Experiment with it, learn, fine-tune, repeat.

After multiple learning journeys and fine-tuning, when desired performance is reliable, convert the prototype into an institutionalised mechanism.

Apply this thinking in every function.

This phase is never finished. That is the point.

EXERCISES

Exercise: The Twelve-Phase Tracker

Build a shared tracker, visible to the full leadership team, with one row per phase.

#	Phase	Owner	Start Date
1	Educate on NFR		
2	Implement NFR (Self & Leadership)		
3	Project Whitespace		
4	The Sensing Journey		
5	Purpose		
6	Strategy		
7	Train the Leaders		
8	Redesign the Organisation		
9	Redesign Performance Management		
10	Train and Develop All Levels		
11	Put Systems in Place		
12	Prototype, Prototype, Prototype		

Review the progress monthly.

YOUR NOTES

10

Sustaining Greatness

Excellence is not a destination. It is the discipline of never mistaking an achievement for an arrival.

The Five-Year View

Five years on, the picture is clear.

Revenue is more than tenfold. Profitability is more than fifteen times. A leadership team that regards its current success not as something to protect but as the foundation for the next level of ambition. A workforce that carries genuine pride in its association with the organization.

The leaders mentioned in this book, who committed fully to the transformation, describe a quality of organizational life that is categorically different from what they started with. The difference is not visible in the numbers alone. It is visible in how decisions get made, how accountability distributes

itself, and how purpose informs daily choices at every level without requiring constant reinforcement from the top. That is what a sustained High-Performance Organization feels like from the inside: performance as the natural result of how things are done here.

A national business channel, in its series profiling leaders who have built extraordinary organizations, recently brought together four such leaders for a sustained conversation. What follows is an edited account of that exchange.

The Long Game: A Panel Conversation

Panel members: Mr. Kumar, Managing Director, technology services firm, Karnataka. Ms. Priya Desai, Chief Operating Officer, manufacturing company, Gujarat. Dr. Raghavan, Chairman, diversified conglomerate, South India. Mr. Pandya, Managing Director, manufacturing company, Maharashtra.

Moderator: "Let us begin with some challenges in this transformation journey. What did you have to let go of that you did not expect?"

Mr. Kumar: "The answer most leaders don't want to give publicly is this: we lost people. Some of them were genuinely strong performers by the metrics we had previously used to evaluate performance. What those metrics did not capture was the degree to which certain individuals were optimising for their own function, unmindful of the organization as a whole.

"Over time, we got clarity on who had the capacity and the willingness to collaborate and co-create and who were solo players. Two people I had regarded as irreplaceable chose to leave. That was difficult initially, but all other leaders rose to the occasion, and the rest is history."

Mr. Pandya: "The personnel dimension Mr. Kumar describes connects directly to how we think about recruitment now, and the shift there has been equally significant. For most of our history, we hired for domain competence and assumed that cultural alignment would follow. What we discovered is that it rarely follows automatically; it has to be designed for. We are now explicit in our recruitment process about the KASH, Knowledge, Attitude, Skills, Habits (Work Habits & Processes), requirements. We have more clarity on who can be suitable for us and who we can be suitable for."

Moderator: "Dr. Raghavan, your organization's transformation centred significantly on a shift from centralised to distributed leadership. Five years on, what does organizational accountability actually look like in practice?"

Dr. Raghavan: "I had spent two decades building the organization as an extension of me. I was influencing, controlling everything. The pattern was so deeply embedded that even after I had made a deliberate and genuine commitment to change it, I found myself reverting to it in moments of pressure. Only when managers started speaking up and discussing issues proactively and even started

arguing with me like partners, I realised that the company had now matured and I am not alone anymore."

Moderator: "Ms. Desai, what has been your journey of the last five years?"

Ms. Priya Desai: "It started with getting frustrated with the follow-up culture that our organizations, and many more organizations, had become. We seriously took on the NFR, No Follow-Up Required, doctrine.

"Our most senior leadership team achieved NFRL certification, No Follow-Up Required Leader, within the first 8 months of committing to the standard, and they are now reliable to maintain that standard over time. The more demanding work has been extending the standard into the team and departmental layers, which we refer to as NFRT and NFRD. Some functions have genuinely absorbed the standard into their operating practice. Others are still in transition, much better than before – but not as reliable as we would wish them to be. Company-wide NFRC, No Follow-Up Required Company, is also a work in progress, and we are making good progress there."

Moderator: "What continues to demand sustained leadership attention, even at this stage of the journey?"

Mr. Pandya: "Purpose and strategy. This is like Mount Neverest (Never Rest). Our practice of taking two days each month for leadership-level reflection has not diminished in

the five years since we began it. If anything, it has become more rigorous because the organization has grown and the environment has evolved, and the questions we need to bring to those two days have become more consequential. The discipline of those sessions is the mechanism by which we catch drift before it compounds."

Moderator: "Was there a period during which any of you seriously considered that the transformation might not hold?"

Everyone laughed in recognition. Almost everyone said the same thing, many more times than I care to count. It is never a done deal. This is a live game, all the time. The moments of success are surrounded by enough challenges that while we celebrate the success, we are always mindful of the next thing that we need to address.

Mr. Kumar measured his words: "The first six months were manageable. Then the uncertainties started to trouble us. The next twelve months were challenging. The space shifted after we secured two significant orders from very important customers, after extensive efforts by our cross-functional teams. That success validated our strategy, and then we have been in a different orbit."

Moderator: "A closing question, to each of you. If you could communicate a single insight to a leader at the beginning of this journey, what would it be?"

Mr. Kumar: "The commitment is the easy part. Going beyond the voice of cynicism of the whole team is the real challenge. Transforming them and getting them on board as co-creators is the game changer."

Ms. Priya Desai: "The follow-up culture was the most expensive thing we were doing, and we had no visibility of it until we measured it."

Dr. Raghavan: "You are not the answer to every question your organization will face. The sooner you get into dialogue culture and collective leadership, the better."

Mr. Pandya: "Two days a month for reflection appeared to be a luxury we could not afford. It turned out to be the best investment we have ever made. It is not comparable to anything else we did."

What Separates the Leaders Who Arrive

The pattern across these four organizations is not identical. The industries differ, the starting conditions differ, the pace of change differs. What they share is a quality of commitment that did not succumb to the challenges of the journey. They decided, and then they kept deciding, every time the decision became inconvenient.

The Return

We began this book with a question: Are you building a High-Performance organization, or a BUSY one? The question has

not changed. What has changed, if you have done the work, is you. Excellence is not a destination. It never was. It is the discipline of never mistaking an achievement for an arrival. That discipline is yours to carry now.

ROAR: The Complete Arc

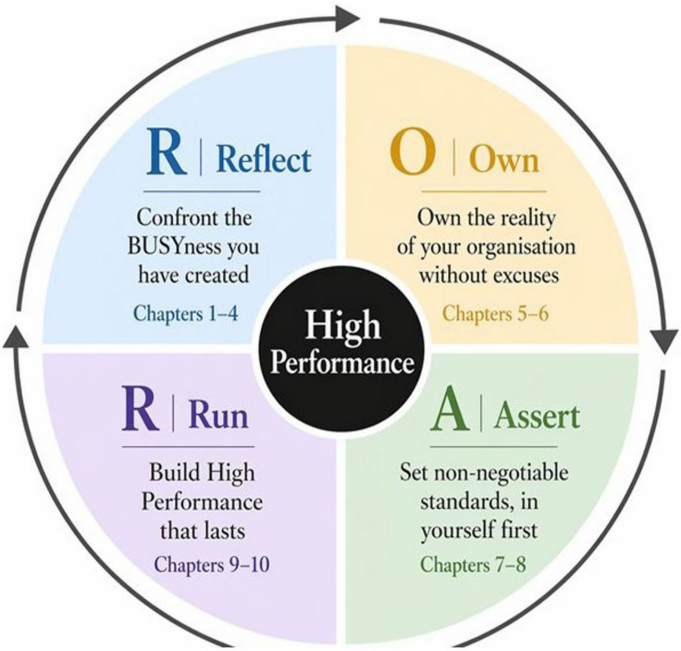
R, Reflect. You examined what you had built. You identified the purpose gap, the strategy gap, the competency compromise. You measured the follow-up cost. You looked into the mirror.

O, Own. You took responsibility for the organization's condition. You identified what BUSYness was concealing. You chose to lead from accountability rather than from position.

A, Assert. You established non-negotiable standards, beginning with yourself. You demanded what you were demonstrating. You named the gap and closed it.

R, Run. You built the twelve-phase implementation plan. The work has begun. The standard holds.

Now and Always, ROAR.



KILL BUSYness.

Begin High Performance.

YOUR NOTES

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"BUSYness isn't a time management problem.

It isn't a people problem.

It is a leadership problem."

Your organisation is full of hardworking, committed people. Everyone is busy. Yet the results aren't what they could be. Problems keep recurring. Good people are quietly disengaging. The strategy exists in a document but not in daily decisions.

The name for it Is **BUSYness.**
This book is its cure.



MANOJ ONKAR

Founder, Management Innovations
www.managementinnovations.co.in
www.KILLBUSYness.com

About The Book



KILL BUSYness

Your calendar is full. Your team is exhausted. And revenue still isn't moving.

Sound familiar?

Somewhere along the way, most organizations made a quiet trade. They swapped progress for motion. Meaning for meetings. Ownership for endless follow-up. Nobody chose it on purpose, it just accumulated, one unfollowed commitment, one reactive decision, one skipped moment of real thinking at a time. Until BUSYness became the culture. And nobody questioned it anymore.

This book does.

Drawing on more than 25 years of consulting with CEOs and leadership teams across India, Thailand, the Philippines, and beyond, Manoj Onkar names what most leaders have felt but never diagnosed: BUSYness isn't a time-management problem. It's a leadership outcome, created at the top, normalized in the middle, and suffered at the bottom.

Through the ROAR model: Reflect, Own, Assert, Run; this book gives you a precise, demanding pathway out. Not another productivity hack. A fundamental shift in how you lead, decide, and hold standards, starting with yourself.

You'll meet leaders like Rajesh, who cancelled a week of meetings to save his company and Priya, who realized her team wasn't running a business, it was running a chase machine. Their stories are yours, too.

If you're ready to stop mistaking activity for progress, this book is the mirror. What you do next is the beginning.

Read honestly. Reflect deeply. Build seriously.

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